Fathers in Offices, Sons in Jobs: Intergenerational Returns to Local Political Office

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Abstract

This paper studies how local political officeholding shapes economic opportunities across generations. I digitize rosters of township, village, and city officials in Ohio from 1912 to 1929 and link them to full-count U.S. censuses to trace the labor-market outcomes of their adult children. Using a matched difference-in-differences design, I find that fathers' entry into office increases sons' occupational income and their likelihood of entering white-collar occupations, with effects persisting for decades. Effects on daughters are more limited in this period of low female labor force participation. One important channel is access to public employment. Sons' public-sector employment rises after fathers enter office, particularly in the postal service and local government, and in settings where hiring is less constrained by civil-service rules. Fathers' officeholding also increases sons' entry into private-sector white-collar occupations, especially in cities and sectors where interactions with local government are more important. Finally, I provide suggestive evidence of broader distributional consequences: townships with greater exposure to officials' sons in public employment subsequently exhibit higher income inequality, while I find no comparable relationship in cities.

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1 Introduction

Labor market opportunities are central to income and economic mobility, yet their allocation does not depend solely on individual ability, effort, or qualifications. Social ties shape access to employment (Kramarz and Skans, 2014), particularly when they are combined with influence over hiring or relationships with employers. Political office provides one important source of such influence: officeholders can directly affect public appointments and can also be valuable to private firms that interact with government (Colonnelli et al., 2020; Gagliarducci and Manacorda, 2020). Political power therefore shapes not only how public resources are distributed, but potentially also who gains access to labor market opportunities.

Much of the existing evidence on the private returns to political power comes from relatively prominent politicians or higher-level offices (Fisman, 2001; Fisman et al., 2014; Dal Bó et al., 2009). Yet most political offices are local (Trounstine, 2009), where officials operate in close proximity to public agencies and local businesses. It is less clear whether these relatively modest positions generate economic advantages for officials' families, and whether such preferential access has broader consequences for the distribution of opportunity within local communities. Anecdotal evidence from Dayton, Ohio, illustrates how directly such advantages could arise: shortly after taking office, the city's newly elected mayor appointed his son as chief clerk, replacing an employee who had held the position for eight years (The Dayton Herald, 1906). Such cases raise a broader question: how can even relatively modest forms of political authority shape the allocation of labor market opportunity?

This paper approaches this question by asking whether a parent's entry into local office improves the labor-market outcomes of their adult children, through what channels these advantages arise, and whether the consequences remain confined to politicians' families or extend to broader economic outcomes within their communities. I study these questions in early twentieth-century Ohio, a setting with thousands of township, village, and city governments and substantial variation in the institutions governing local public employment. In particular, many municipalities adopted civil service systems during this period to restrict discretionary public-sector hiring (Kuipers and Sahn, 2023; Anzia and Trounstine, 2025), providing useful variation for examining how local officeholding generates advantages for officials' children. To do so, I construct a new dataset of township, village, and city officials from the *Ohio Rosters of Township and Municipal Officers*, covering approximately 180,000 year-office observations across more than 2,000 local governments between 1912 and 1929. I link these officials to the full-count U.S. censuses and use the Census Tree Project crosswalks developed by Buckles et al. (2025) to identify their children and trace their outcomes from 1900 to 1940. Because local officeholders during this period were overwhelmingly male, the analysis focuses on fathers' entry into office and the subsequent outcomes of their adult children.

I first document who became local officials. Local officials during this period were not generally drawn from the economic elite. Although they had somewhat higher occupational income before entering office than the general population, their own occupations and their fathers' occupational ranks place them largely in the middle of the local income distribution. This pattern is particularly pronounced in villages and townships, where officials' economic backgrounds closely resemble those of the broader working-age male population. These patterns suggest that local political office was accessible to individuals outside the economic elite, making it possible to study whether political office can generate intergenerational economic advantages even among relatively ordinary families.

To identify the effect of a father's officeholding on children's labor-market outcomes, I use a matched difference-in-differences design that compares adult children of officials with observationally similar adult children whose fathers do not hold office, in censuses before and after the father's entry into office. I match individuals on detailed pre-office characteristics of both fathers and children, including age, gender, birthplace, county of residence, immigrant status, literacy, and occupational income, and show balance on additional characteristics not used in the matching procedure. The analysis focuses on children who had already reached working age before their fathers entered office, allowing me to trace changes in their labor-market trajectories around office entry while limiting the scope for mechanisms operating through earlier investments in children's human capital.

Although officials were drawn from a broad range of economic and occupational backgrounds, entry into political office may still be selective along dimensions that are difficult to observe. Fathers who become officials may differ in ambition, political engagement, networks, or other characteristics that could also affect their children's labor-market outcomes. I address this concern using two complementary designs. First, I compare children whose fathers enter office at a given point in time with children whose fathers enter office only a few years later, exploiting differences in the narrow window of timing of office entry among families that ultimately receive treatment. Second, where electoral returns are available, I compare the children of the elected candidate receiving the fewest votes with those of the unelected candidate receiving the most votes. These designs reduce concerns on comparisons between political and nonpolitical families and compare individuals from families with similar political ambitions and resources.

I find that fathers' entry into local office improves sons' labor-market outcomes. Occupational income rises by about 2.3 percent, driven primarily by a 2 percentage point increase in white-collar employment, and these gains persist for decades after fathers enter office. Using wage income reported in the 1940 Census, I also find that sons of officials earn approximately 13 percent more than their matched counterparts. The results are not driven solely by differences between political and nonpolitical families. The same positive post-entry pattern appears when I compare sons whose fathers enter office with sons whose fathers will enter office shortly thereafter. A complementary comparison between children of the lowest-vote elected and highest-vote unelected candidates yields a similar positive pattern, although the estimates are less precise because of the smaller sample.

The effects on daughters' labor-market outcomes are more limited in this context, where female labor-force participation was only around 22 percent in Ohio.[1] Fathers' officeholding does not affect daughters' labor-force participation, and on average there is no effect on daughters' labor-market outcomes. Among daughters who work, fathers' officeholding increases occupational income by about 3 percent, similar in magnitude to the effect for sons, although the estimate is only marginally significant. There is little evidence of systematic shifts across white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skill, and agricultural occupations. I also find little evidence that daughters benefit through marriage that fathers' officeholding does not affect whether their daughters marry to better-occupation husbands or husbands from better family backgrounds.

I next examine how local officeholding improves sons' occupational outcomes. One important channel is preferential access to public-sector employment. Fathers' entry into office increases sons' probability of public employment by about 1.2 percentage points, roughly 70 percent relative to the control-group mean. The increase is concentrated in local-government and postal employment, where local political influence and recommendation networks could plausibly matter, with no corresponding increase in state or other federal employment. Public-sector gains are also substantially larger in villages and townships, where hiring was less constrained by civil-service rules, than in cities. Within cities, the occupational gains from fathers' officeholding are substantially attenuated after civil-service adoption; the corresponding estimate for public employment is also negative, although imprecisely estimated. Together, these patterns suggest that local officeholding

[1] The figure is calculated using the 1920 Census.

facilitated sons' access to public-sector employment, particularly where formal constraints on hiring were weaker.

Political advantage also extends to private-sector employment. Fathers' officeholding increases sons' probability of entering private-sector white-collar occupations by about 1.7 percentage points. The effect is largest in cities, where private-sector opportunities and interactions between firms and local government are more extensive, and is concentrated in wholesale and retail trade and finance, insurance, and real estate. These patterns are consistent with political connections improving sons' access to firms and sectors in which relationships with local government are valuable. The data, however, do not distinguish whether these gains reflect employer demand for politically connected workers, recommendations by officials, or broader political and social networks. Within cities, these private-sector white-collar gains are particularly larger under civil-service adoption, suggesting that restricting discretion in public-sector hiring may redirect some political advantage toward private-sector opportunities.

Finally, I explore whether intergenerational political advantage has broader distributional consequences within local communities. Because officials' sons are not exogenously allocated to public-sector jobs or across localities, I interpret this analysis as suggestive. Townships with greater exposure to officials' sons in public employment subsequently exhibit higher income inequality, measured by both the Gini coefficient and the income share of the top decile, while I find no comparable relationship in cities. One interpretation is that preferential access is more consequential in thinner labor markets, where desirable jobs are relatively scarce and alternative opportunities are more limited. These patterns point to a potential distributional cost of intergenerational political advantage that extends beyond politically connected families, especially in thinner labor markets.

This paper contributes to three strands of literature. First, it contributes to the literature on the private returns to political office. A growing body of work shows that holding office can increase politicians' wealth and income (Fisman et al., 2014; Eggers and Hainmueller, 2009). Beyond officeholders themselves, political connections may also improve the labor market outcomes of their family members, as documented across several countries using shared family names to proxy for political ties (Gagliarducci and Manacorda, 2020; Fafchamps and Labonne, 2017). Yet less is known about how holding office affects the economic trajectories of politicians' children over the longer run. The closest work is Folke et al. (2017), who study newly elected mayors in Sweden and find earnings gains among their children that are not attributable to nepotistic public-sector hiring. In contrast, this paper finds that public-sector employment is an important margin of intergenerational advantage in settings where local hiring is less constrained, highlighting the role of hiring institutions in shaping how political advantage is transmitted. Ho (2025) studies historical U.S. congressional and gubernatorial elections and finds that electoral victory temporarily increases children's occupational income. I instead study a broad set of routine local offices at township, village, and city level, and find occupational gains for sons that persist for decades after fathers enter office. Beyond documenting these effects, I also examine the channels through which they arise, showing that political advantage extends to both public-sector employment and private-sector white-collar opportunities.

This paper also speaks to the literature on patronage and nepotism. Existing literature shows that politicians may allocate resources on the basis of political loyalty and personal connections, with public employment as one important margin (Cruz et al., 2017; Leucht, 2023; Colonnelli et al., 2020). In particular, Colonnelli et al. (2020) show that political connection shapes who gets hired in the public sector and the bureaucratic quality. Such practices can weaken state capacity and affect economic development (Xu, 2018; Aneja and Xu, 2024). I add an intergenerational dimension to this literature by showing that fathers' officeholding increases sons' access to public employment and that these gains are larger in settings where formal constraints on local hiring are weaker. The evidence from civil-service reform further suggests that institutional restrictions can change the form of political advantage: occupational gains are attenuated after reform, while private-sector white-collar gains become larger. The exploratory township analysis points to a potential distributional consequence of these family-level advantages beyond politically connected families themselves.

Finally, the paper adds to the literature on intergenerational mobility and the transmission of economic advantage. A large body of work documents substantial intergenerational persistence in human capital, income, and occupation (Barrios-Fernández et al., 2026; Dal Bó et al., 2009; Kramarz and Skans, 2014; Long and Ferrie, 2013; Mocetti, 2016). More closely related is work examining how parental access to political power shapes children's opportunities in politics (Dal Bó et al., 2009). This paper highlights a different margin: how a parent's acquisition of political power changes the economic opportunities of children who are already adults. Because the children in the analysis had reached working age before their fathers entered office, the estimated gains are unlikely to operate primarily through childhood investments in human capital. Instead, the results show that changes in parents' political position can reshape their adult children's access to jobs and their subsequent occupational trajectories.

2 Data and Descriptive Statistics

2.1 Data

2.1.1 Ohio Roster of Township and Municipal Officers

My main source of data is *Ohio Rosters of Township and Municipal Officers* (Ohio Secretary of State, 1929) (hereafter, the rosters). The rosters are published biennially by the Ohio Secretary of State and provide a listing of local officials organized by county, locality (township, village, and city), and office. The offices include both elected and appointed officials, such as township trustees, clerks, and treasurers, as well as village mayors, council members, and city mayors, council members, judges, etc, which together oversaw local administration, finance, and public services. Most of these positions were through local elections taking place every two years. Table B1 summarizes these offices by different forms of government. I digitized 9 consecutive rosters covering the years 1912 through 1929.[2] Figure C1, C2, and C3 show the example pages of the rosters.

In total, my dataset includes 179,952 year-office observations spanning offices in 95 cities, 862 villages, and 1,518 townships.

2.1.2 Linking the Rosters to the Census

To obtain demographic characteristics and intergenerational information for local officials, I link the individuals listed in the rosters to the full-count U.S. censuses (Ruggles et al., 2024).

I link each official listed in the rosters to the contemporaneous full-count censuses based on their name and location using an automated procedure that proceeds in two stages. I first attempt to link each official to the closest pre-office census. For example, officials in the 1914 roster are initially matched to individuals in the 1910 census. A match is defined when there is a unique individual in the census who satisfies three baseline criteria: (1) the same first and last name; (2) residence in the same county as the roster record; and (3) being at least 25 years old at the time of entry into office.[3] If multiple candidates meet

[2] Volumes were published before 1912 and after 1929, but not in a continuous series. I restrict attention to 1912 - 1929 in order to maintain a consecutive series of rosters.

[3] For some officials, the rosters only reported the initial of their first name. In this case, I also link them to the censuses based on the initial of the first name. As a robustness check, I show that the main results remain when excluding links for officials that report only initials of their first names.

these conditions, I incorporate additional criteria: middle name consistency and locality, i.e., township or municipality, of residence in the census.[4] A match is defined if there is a unique individual record in the census that satisfies the criteria (1) − (3) and (4) that there is no conflict in the middle name; or satisfies the criteria (1) − (4) and (5) that the individual resides in the same town or municipality as the office locality recorded in the roster.

If no match is found in the closest pre-office census, I then turn to the closest post-office census. For instance, an official in the 1914 Roster who cannot be linked in the 1910 census will then be linked to potential records in the 1920 census. The same sequence of matching criteria and tie-breaking rules is applied until either a unique match is found or no eligible candidate remains.

Using this procedure, I successfully link approximately 70% of the office-year records in the rosters to individuals in the full-count censuses.[5] Between 1912 and 1928, I matched 57,936 unique officials in the rosters. Table B2 reports the linkage rates in detail, disaggregated by roster year and form of government.

2.1.3 Collecting Information on Winning and Losing Candidates

To complement the study, I construct a separate dataset of local election candidates. Starting from the names of officials listed in the rosters, I search historical newspapers around election dates for coverage of local elections. Figure A2 provides an example of such election coverage. Whenever election coverage is available, I digitize candidates' names, offices, locality, and votes. This procedure allows me to get information on losing candidates, who are not recorded in the rosters.

The resulting dataset covers around 290 races, mostly for city governments and races for mayors and council members. Although this sample is smaller than the Rosters-based sample, it provides a useful complementary source of variation for comparing winning and losing candidates.

[4] The locality (township or municipality) information is obtained from the Census Place Project (Berkes et al., 2023).

[5] This linkage rate is higher than what is commonly achieved in historical census linkage, reflecting the detailed name and location information available for local officials. Meanwhile, most of these officials are white, who have on average higher linking rate. This linking rate is comparable to that reported by Abramitzky et al. (2024), who link university faculty rosters to the full-count censuses.

2.2 Descriptive: Characteristics of Local Officials

Having linked local officials in the rosters to the full-count censuses, I obtain their demographic characteristics and pre-office economic backgrounds. Table 1 reports summary statistics for local officials (Panel A) and compares them to the general population of Ohio from the 1920 Census (Panel B). Relative to the population, local officials are overwhelmingly male and less likely to be foreign-born. They also have higher occupational income scores, which is a measure of median income observed in the 1950 Census by each occupation,[6] prior to entering office, indicating positive selection into local political positions. The average official enters office approximately at age 47, suggesting that local officeholding typically occurs later in the working life rather than at labor market entry.

Figure 1 provides a more detailed view of officials' economic backgrounds by plotting the distribution of pre-office occupational income scores and family background separately for city, village, and township governments. Panels A, C, and E compare officials' pre-office occupational income distributions to those of the working-age male population. Across all three settings, officials tend to come from occupations with higher income scores than the average population, though they are not concentrated in the extreme upper tail of the distribution. This pattern is most pronounced in cities, where officials' occupational distribution is clearly shifted to the right relative to the general population. In contrast, township officials are concentrated in the lower and middle portions of the occupational distribution, substantially overlapping with the average male population and only a limited presence in the upper tail. Village officials fall between these two cases, exhibiting modest positive selection relative to the population in terms of occupational background.

Panels B, D, and F examine officials' family backgrounds, measured by the percentile rank of their fathers' occupational income scores within their fathers' cohort when these officials were young. City officials tend to come from more advantaged families, although not concentrated at the very top of the distribution. Village and township officials, by contrast, are substantially more likely to come from families with modest occupational backgrounds. Taken together, these patterns indicate that while local officials were positively selected relative to the general population, especially in cities, township and village offices were broadly accessible to individuals from middle-class backgrounds rather than being dominated by economic elites.

[6] The income information is not available until the 1940 Census.

Table 1. Baseline Characteristics

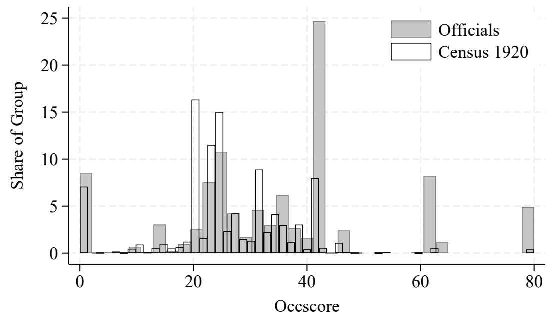
	All Mean	*City* Mean	*Village* Mean	*Township* Mean
Panel A: Local officials				
Male	0.936	0.926	0.925	0.950
White	0.985	0.984	0.982	0.988
Age first in office	46.702	46.937	45.792	47.597
Foreign born	0.034	0.055	0.036	0.025
Immigrant parents	0.213	0.290	0.212	0.193
Literate	0.984	0.986	0.981	0.987
Pre-office occscore	21.569	31.757	23.664	16.507
Pre-office public sector	0.022	0.069	0.021	0.010
Obs	57,936	6,634	26,288	25,014
Panel B: Population (Census 1920)				
Male	0.513	0.511	0.493	0.524
White	0.967	0.957	0.978	0.987
Age	29.224	28.418	31.686	28.927
Foreign born	0.119	0.194	0.050	0.051
Immigrant parents	0.332	0.488	0.187	0.177
Literate	0.971	0.963	0.980	0.976
Occscore	13.803	15.820	13.555	9.384
Public sector	0.007	0.010	0.007	0.003
Obs	5,763,198	1,764,029	505,897	1,452,462

Note: Panel A reports characteristics of local officials linked to the Census, and Panel B reports corresponding characteristics of the Ohio population in the 1920 Census. For officials' pre-office occupational income score, individuals first observed in office in 19121913 are excluded because they may already have held office by the 1910 Census, so the 1910 observation cannot be reliably treated as pre-office. In Panel B, occupational income scores are calculated for individuals ages 2565.

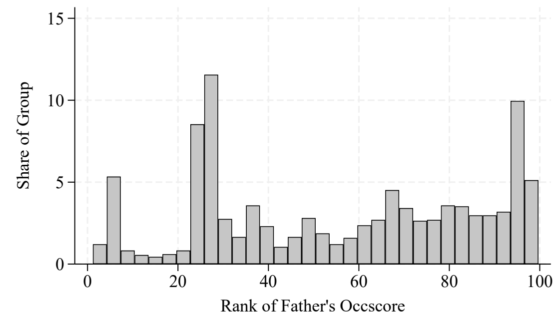
In the Appendix, Figure C4 presents a breakdown of officials' characteristics by year and form of local government, showing that the patterns of pre-office occupational income score for officials are relatively stable over time.

2.3 Linking Officials to Their Family

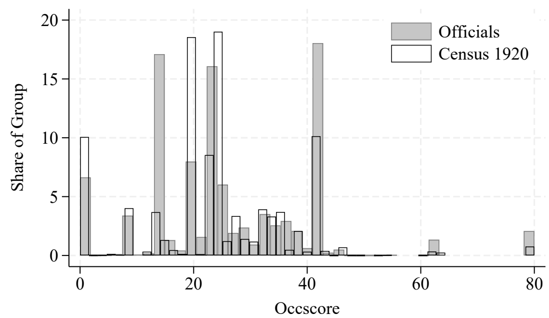
To get the intergenerational information for local officials, I link officials to their children using census-to-census crosswalks from the Census Tree Project (CTP) (Buckles et al., 2025). I first trace each official across earlier census waves to periods when their children



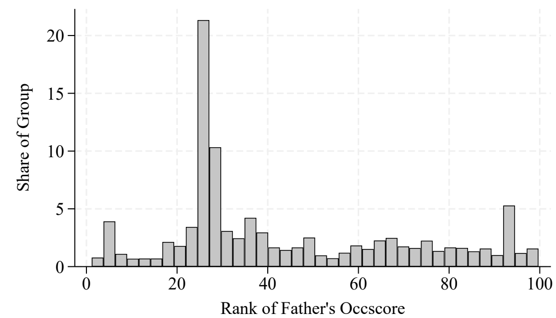
A. Occscore: City



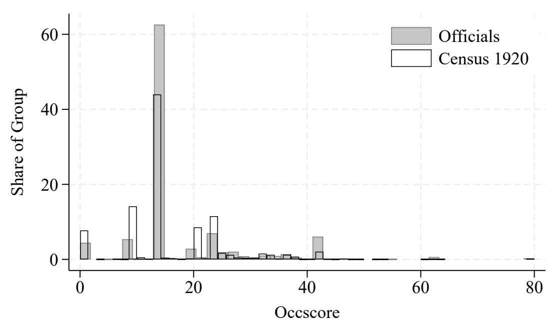
B. Family Background: City



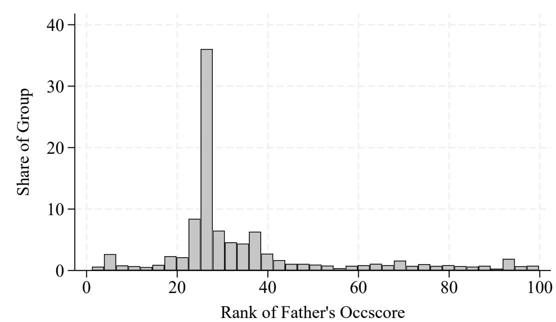
C. Occscore: Village



D. Family Background: Village



E. Occscore: Township



F. Family Background: Township

Figure 1. Distribution of Officials' Pre-office Occupation and Family Background

Note: This figure describes the economic backgrounds of male local officials separately for city, village, and township governments. Panels A, C, and E plot the distribution of officials' pre-office occupational income scores and the corresponding distribution among men ages 2565 in the 1920 Census. Panels B, D, and F plot officials' family backgrounds, measured by the percentile rank of their fathers' occupational income scores within their fathers' birth cohorts.

are likely to reside in the same household. This allows me to identify children directly from the household and recover child identifiers. After identifying children, I use the CTP crosswalks to follow them forward across census waves and construct their labor market outcomes in the full-count censuses from 1900 through 1940. This procedure enables me to observe children's occupational trajectories over much of their working lives and therefore to study the longer-run impact of fathers' officeholding on children's labor market outcomes.

2.4 Outcome Variables

The main outcomes of interest are labor market outcomes, specifically earnings and occupation. Because the full-count censuses did not collect individual earnings information until 1940, I proxy for earnings using the occupational income score measure (OCCSCORE). OCCSCORE is constructed by assigning to each occupation the median income observed in the 1950 Census. The OCCSCORE measure has two limitations: it does not capture within-occupation variation in individual earnings, and it does not reflect changes in the relative earnings of occupations over time. The latter limitation is difficult to address given the absence of individual earnings data for the pre-1940 period. To partially address the former limitation, I use a complementary measure as a robustness check in Section E.3, the Lasso-Industry-Demographic-Occupation (LIDO) scores developed by Saavedra and Twinam (2020), which adjusts occupational earnings by incorporating industry and demographic composition. It is important to note that both the OCCSCORE and LIDO scores provide only occupation-based proxies for labor market outcomes rather than direct measures of earnings.

3 Research Design

As local officials could differ from the general population, a simple comparison between children of local officials and children of non-local officials would yield biased estimates of the intergenerational effects of officeholding. To address this concern, I employ a matched difference-in-differences design that compares changes in outcomes for children whose fathers enter local office to those of observationally similar children whose fathers do not.

3.1 Matching

My sample consists of individuals who had reached working age in the census year prior to their fathers' entry into office. I restrict the sample to the children of officials who began officeholding between 1914 and 1928.[7]

I implement nearest-neighbor matching to pair each child of officials (treated) with a comparable individual whose father never held local office (control). Matching is conducted at the closest pre-office census ($t = -1$). To reduce the likelihood that the control group includes local officials omitted from the rosters, I exclude potential control families in which the father is employed in the public sector at $t = -1$. This restriction uses only pre-office information and is motivated by incomplete reporting of some local offices in the rosters, which I discuss further in Section 4.3. For each treated individual, I select control individuals of the same gender and race, residing in the same county, born in the same state/country, having the same immigration family background, same literacy status, and having the smallest Mahalanobis distance based on age, pre-office occupational income score, father's age, and father's pre-office occupational income score.

Table 2 reports balance tests for both targeted and non-targeted covariates in the matched sample. Children of officials and their matched controls are highly similar along observed demographic and family background characteristics. While there is a statistically significant difference in maternal literacy between the two groups, the magnitude of this difference is very small relative to the sample mean.

3.2 Econometric Specification

To identify the intergenerational impact of fathers' officeholding, I estimate the following difference-in-differences specification using the matched sample:

$$y_{ibct} = \alpha_i + \beta_1(\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}) + \beta_2\text{Post}_{it} + \theta_{bt} + \mu_c + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{ibct} \tag{1}$$

where i denotes individual, b age bins defined in five-year intervals, c county, and t census year. y_{ibct} is the outcome of interest for individual i in year t. $\text{Office}_{j(i)}$ is an indicator equal to one if individual i's father j ever holds local office. Post_{it} equals zero if i's father j hasn't started the term in census year t and one otherwise. For matched controls, Post_{it} is assigned based on the timing of their matched treated counterpart. The specification

[7] Because the roster data are truncated between 1912 and 1928, I exclude children of officials appearing in the 1912–1913 Rosters, as their fathers may have entered office before 1912.

Table 2. Balance Table for Matched Sample: $t = -1$

	Children of Officials		Matched Individuals		Difference Treated - Control	
	(1) Mean	(2) Obs	(3) Mean	(4) Obs	(5) Diff	(6) SE
Targeted variables						
Male	0.519	21,257	0.520	31,780	-0.000	0.005
White	0.998	21,257	0.998	31,780	-0.000	0.001
Foreignborn	0.002	21,257	0.002	31,780	0.000	0.001
Immigrant Parent	0.070	21,257	0.069	31,780	0.001	0.004
Literate	0.996	21,257	0.996	31,780	0.000	0.001
Age	24.941	21,257	24.901	31,780	0.039	0.072
Occscore	12.178	21,257	12.153	31,780	0.025	0.133
Father Literate	0.992	21,257	0.992	31,780	0.000	0.001
Father Occscore	22.186	21,257	21.978	31,780	0.208	0.162
Father Age	54.270	21,257	54.348	31,780	-0.078	0.101
Non-targeted variables						
Married	0.460	21,257	0.458	31,780	0.002	0.005
Num of Kids	0.656	21,257	0.674	31,780	-0.018	0.013
Mother Literate	0.992	19,893	0.985	29,176	0.007***	0.002
Mother Occscore	0.454	19,893	0.393	29,176	0.060	0.045
Mother Age	50.467	19,893	50.329	29,176	0.138	0.107

Note: This table reports covariate balance between officials' adult children and their matched counterparts in the first pre-office Census $t = -1$.
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

includes individual fixed effects α_i, age-bin-at-year fixed effects θ_{bt},[8] county fixed effect μ_c and census year fixed effect γ_t. The regression is weighted by the matching weights to account for cases in which a treated individual is matched to multiple controls. Standard errors are clustered at the father level.

To estimate the dynamic effect, I estimate the following event-study specification:

$$y_{ibct} = \alpha_i + \sum_{k \neq -1} \beta_1^k (\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \mathbf{1}\{t = k\}) + \sum_k \beta_2^k \mathbf{1}\{t = k\} + \theta_{bt} + \mu_c + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{ibct} \qquad (2)$$

[8]The birth cohort fixed effects will be absorbed by the individual fixed effect. Age-bin-at-year fixed effects flexibly control for age profiles, varying within-individual for different census year t. I categorize every five years into one bin.

where $\mathbf{1}\{t = k\}$ are the event time dummies relative to fathers' office entry, with $k = -1$ corresponding to the first pre-office census and $k = 1$ to the first post-office census. This specification allows me to assess both pre-trends and the dynamic response of children's labor market outcomes following fathers' entry into office.

The key identification assumption is that in the absence of the fathers' entry into local office, the labor market evolution of officials' children should be the same as their matched counterparts. While this assumption is not directly testable, I assess its plausibility by examining pre-treatment trends in the event-study analysis. The parallel pre-trends in the pre-office years (Figure 2) support the validity of the research design. Section 4.3 further discusses potential threats to identification and presents additional evidence addressing these concerns.

4 Main Results

This section examines how fathers' entry into local political office affects their adult children's labor market outcomes over the life cycle.

Before turning to the causal analysis of the intergenerational effect on labor market outcomes in Equation 1, I first document raw trends in occupational income scores for officials' children and their matched counterparts. Figure A1 plots average occupational income scores for sons and daughters of officials and their matched controls. In the pre-office period, the trajectories for treated and control individuals closely mirror each other for both sons and daughters. Note that although the matching is conducted at $t = -1$, occupational income scores remain balanced at $t = -2$, providing credibility for the quality of the matching. The close alignment of trends prior to fathers' office entry provides credibility for the identification assumption. Following fathers' entry into office, the trajectories diverge for sons. Sons of officials experience a sustained increase in occupational income relative to their matched counterparts. This advantage persists through at least the third post-office census, suggesting that even low-level political officeholding can generate long-lasting effects on children's career trajectories. In contrast, daughters show no comparable divergence in occupational income following fathers' office entry.

Because female labor force participation was relatively low during the early twentieth century,[9] this section explores the labor market effect by gender.

4.1 Effects on Sons' Labor-Market Outcomes

Table 3 examines the impact of fathers' officeholding on sons' labor market outcomes using the matched difference-in-differences specification. Columns (1) and (2) report estimates for sons' occupational income score. Column (1) reports the result without controlling for individual fixed effects. The small and insignificant coefficient of Office suggests that there is no difference in occupational income score between sons of officials and their matched counterparts before the father enters the office. After the office, the occupational income score for sons of officials increases by 2.7 percent compared to their matched counterparts. Column (2) includes individual fixed effects, comparing the change in occupational income score in the same individual before and after the office time. When partialling out the time-invariant differences across individuals, fathers' officeholding increases sons' income score by 2.3 percent.

Columns (3) to (6) explore occupational changes underlying this increase in occupational income score. I classify occupations into four categories: white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skill, and agricultural occupations. Fathers' officeholding significantly increases sons' probability of working in a white-collar occupation by 2 percentage points, about 10 percent relative to the control-group mean. At the same time, sons of officials become less likely to work in skilled blue-collar occupations, with little change in low-skill employment and a modest decline in agricultural work, although the effect is not statistically significant. These patterns indicate that the improvement in sons' occupational standing is driven primarily by movement into white-collar occupations, which on average have higher earnings.

Because the occupational income score captures only between-occupation differences and not within-occupation earnings variation, the true effect on earning might be different if fathers' officeholding generates within-occupation benefits, which OCCSCORE cannot capture. To provide suggestive evidence on the magnitude of the income effects, I exploit wage income information available in the 1940 Census and compare the wage income of officials' sons and their matched counterparts. Column (7) shows that among sons with observed wage income in 1940, officials' sons earn approximately 13 percent more

[9] The labor force participation rate for working-age (18-64) women is 22.44% and for working-age (18-64) men is 94.62% in Ohio, calculated using the 1920 Census.

than their matched counterparts. This estimate comes from a cross-sectional comparison within matched pairs rather than the panel difference-in-differences specification used in Columns (1) - (6). The magnitude of the effect is comparable to returns from an additional year of schooling (around 9%) documented in the literature (Card, 1999; Psacharopoulos and Patrinos, 2018), suggesting that political officeholding confers non-trivial labor market advantages.

Table 3. Intergenerational impact on sons' labor market outcomes

	Labor-Market Outcome$_{it}$		Occupation Category$_{it}$				Earning$_{1940}$
	(1) Log Occscore	(2) Log Occscore	(3) White collar	(4) Skilled blue collar	(5) Low skill	(6) Agricultural	(7) Log wage income
Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	0.027***	0.023***	0.020***	-0.008*	-0.000	-0.007	
	(0.007)	(0.006)	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.007)	(0.006)	
Office$_{j(i)}$	0.005						0.129***
	(0.007)						(0.023)
Individual FE		Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Pair FE							Y
Control Mean	22.133	22.133	0.209	0.142	0.385	0.257	1287.692
R^2	0.160	0.715	0.686	0.575	0.544	0.638	0.610
Observations	81981	81981	84173	84173	84173	84173	11176

Note: This table reports estimates of the effect of fathers' local officeholding on sons' labor-market outcomes. Columns (1)–(6) use the matched panel sample with the unit of observation being the individualcensus-year. Columns (1) and (2) examine log occupational income score (OCCSCORE), while Columns (3)–(6) examine indicators for employment in white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skill, and agricultural occupations, respectively. The sample includes matched sons who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office Census and are observed in 1900 – 1940. Column (7) uses a cross-sectional sample of matched sons observed in the 1940 Census and examines log wage income. Office equals one if individual i's father j ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post$_{it}$ equals one in census years after father j first enters office and zero before entry. Matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. The control mean reports the mean of the dependent variable in levels among matched controls in the estimation sample (Mean of Occscore for Columns (1) – (2) and mean of wage income for Column (7)). Standard errors are clustered at the father level in Columns (1)-(6) and at the matched-pair level in Column (7).
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

I next examine the dynamics of the effect of fathers' officeholding on sons' occupational outcomes by estimating the event-study specification in Equation 2. Figure 2 shows no evidence of differential pre-trends between sons of officials and their matched counterparts prior to fathers' office entry, supporting the identification assumption. Following fathers' office entry, sons' occupational income increases relative to their matched counterparts. The effect appears in the first post-office census and persists for at least two subsequent census decades. Figure 3 further shows that the persistent increase in sons' occupational income score following their fathers' office entry is driven primarily by persistent increases in white-collar employment. The dynamic results indicate that fathers' local officeholding shapes sons' long-run occupational trajectories rather than producing temporary income gains.

Section E.2 explores the heterogeneity in the intergenerational effects of fathers' officeholding by sons' age at the time of fathers' office entry and by sibling composition. Figure E6 examines the heterogeneity by sons' age when their fathers first enter office. There is not much heterogeneity for sons aged below 40 when their father starts the office and the effect of fathers' office declines to zero for sons who were already in their forties when their fathers entered office. Figure E7 explores heterogeneity by sibling composition. The effects are somewhat larger for first-born sons relative to later-born sons and for sons without sisters relative to sons with sisters, although the effects are not significantly different. And the effects do not vary by sibling size.

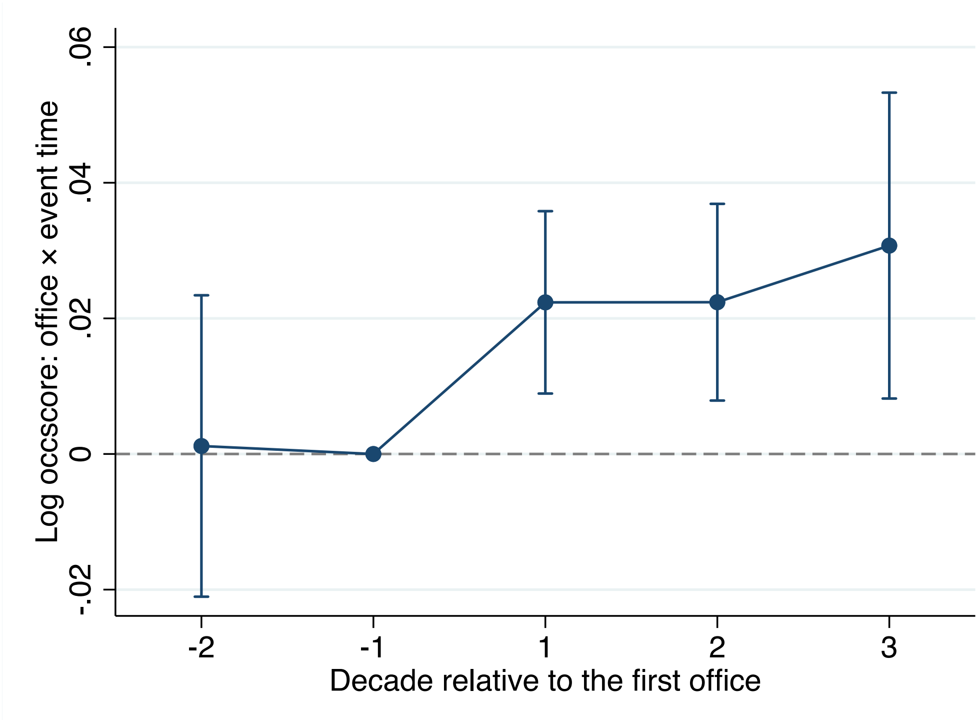


Figure 2. Dynamic Effect of Fathers' Officeholding on Son's Occupational Income
Note: This figure presents the dynamics of sons' occupational income from estimating Equation 2. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

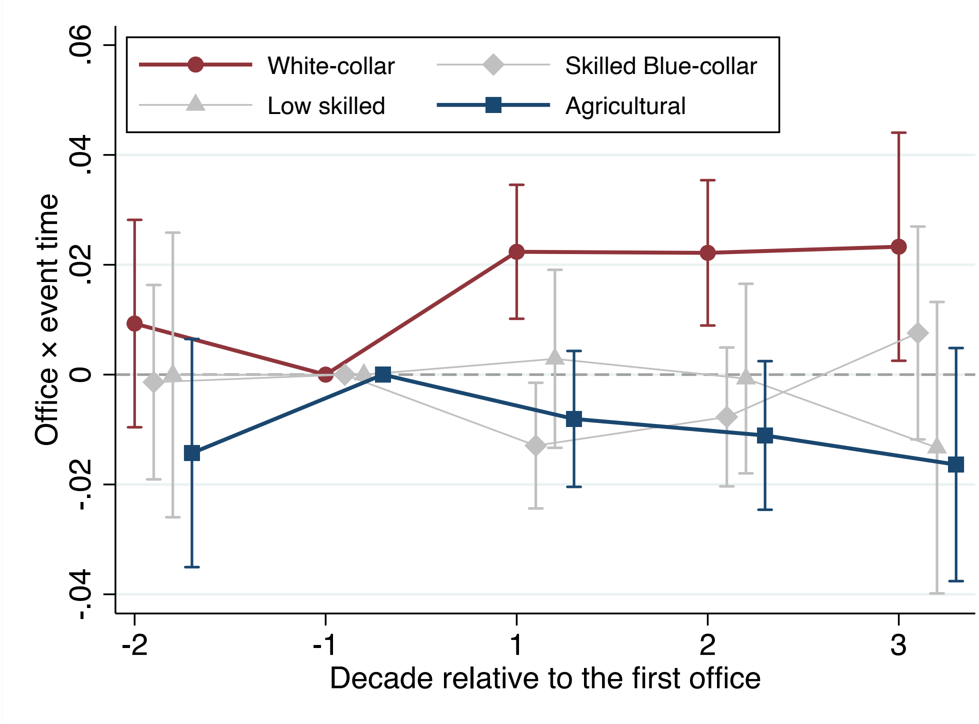


Figure 3. Dynamic Effect of Office on Son's Occupational Category
Note: This figure presents the dynamics of sons' occupation categories from estimating Equation 2. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

4.2 Effects on Daughters' Outcomes

This section examines the impact of fathers' officeholding on daughters' labor-market outcomes. This scenario is somewhat different compared to the analysis of sons. Female labor force participation was relatively low during the sample period, and women's labor force participation was attached to life-cycle events such as marriage. I therefore first examine whether fathers' officeholding affects daughters' labor force participation and, conditional on working, their occupational outcomes. I then consider marriage as an alternative margin through which daughters might benefit from their fathers' political position.

Table 4 reports the labor-market results. Column (1) shows no evidence that fathers' officeholding affects daughters' labor-force participation. The estimated effect is close to zero relative to a control-group labor force participation rate of 14.9 percent. Figure E1 presents the corresponding event-study estimates and shows no change in daughters' labor force participation after fathers' office entry.

Among daughters who work, Column (2) shows that working daughters of officials have occupational income scores approximately 3.1 percent higher than those of their matched counterparts. This estimate is similar and if anything larger in magnitude to the corresponding effect for sons, although it is only marginally statistically significant. The occupation category outcomes provide less evidence of broad occupational upgrading. Columns (3) to (6) show no systematic shifts into white-collar work or away from skilled blue-collar, low-skilled, or agricultural occupations. The increase in OCCSCORE therefore appears to reflect changes within these broad occupational groups rather than a clear reallocation across them. Column (7) provides an additional comparison using wage income from the 1940 Census. The estimated wage advantage for working daughters of officials is positive and similar in magnitude to the corresponding estimate for sons, but it is imprecisely estimated and statistically insignificant.

The event study estimates reinforce this interpretation. Figure E2 shows that the increase in occupational standing among working daughters emerges only in later periods after fathers enter office, while Figure E3 shows little systematic change across broad occupational categories. These estimates should nevertheless be interpreted cautiously: unlike for sons, occupational outcomes are observed only for the relatively small and selected group of daughters who participate in the labor market.

To assess daughters' outcomes without conditioning on labor-force participation, Appendix Table E1 and Figure E4 assign an OCCSCORE of zero to nonworking daughters and estimates the effect in the full sample of working-age daughters. This outcome combines extensive margin of whether a daughter participates in market work and intensive margin of the occupational standing of daughters' jobs if they work, and should therefore be interpreted as an overall measure of daughters' labor market outcomes. Across alternative transformations of OCCSCORE and estimation methods, the estimates are small and statistically insignificant. Hence, the suggestive gains observed among working daughters do not translate into a detectable improvement in labor-market outcomes for daughters in general.

The limited evidence of gains in daughters' labor-market outcomes in general raises the possibility that fathers' officeholding might matter for daughters through a different margin. In a setting where female labor force participation is low, political status could instead improve daughters' economic position through marriage, for example by facilitating matches with more advantaged husbands. Appendix Section E.1.1 examines this possibility. Table E2 provides little evidence that fathers' officeholding leads to more advantageous marital matches along the dimensions observable in the census. Daughters whose fathers enter office are not more likely to be married to white-collar or public-sector husbands, and their husbands do not have significantly higher occupational income scores or come from families with higher occupational standing. I also examine whether fathers' officeholding subsequently improves the labor-market outcomes of sons-in-law. Figure E5 shows no systematic increase in sons-in-law's occupational income score following their fathers-in-law's entry into office.

Table 4. Effects of Fathers' Officeholding on Daughters' Labor-Market Outcomes

	Labor-Market Outcome$_{it}$		Occupation Category$_{it}$				Earning$_{1940}$
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
	LFP	Log Occscore	White collar	Skilled blue collar	Low skill	Agricultural	Log wage income
Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	-0.003	0.031*	0.008	0.004	-0.007	-0.004	
	(0.006)	(0.019)	(0.018)	(0.008)	(0.018)	(0.005)	
Office$_{j(i)}$							0.132
							(0.154)
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Pair FE							Y
Control Mean	0.149	22.128	0.646	0.021	0.319	0.015	803.614
R^2	0.514	0.752	0.794	0.567	0.784	0.622	0.728
Observations	91022	15764	15764	15764	15764	15764	2540

Note: This table reports estimates of the effect of fathers' local officeholding on daughters' labor-market outcomes. Columns (1)–(6) use the matched panel sample with the unit of observation being the individualcensus-year. The dependent variable in Column (1) is an indicator for labor-force participation. The dependent variable in Column (2) is log occupational income score (OCCSCORE), conditional on the working daughters. The dependent variables in Columns (3)–(6) are indicators for employment in white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skilled, and agricultural occupations, respectively, also conditional on labor-force participation. These columns include matched daughters who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office census and are observed in the 1900–1940 Censuses; Column (1) excludes the 1900 Census because labor-force participation is not observed. Column (7) uses the 1940 Census and examines log wage income among matched daughters observed in the 1940 Census. Office equals one if individual i's father j ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post$_{it}$ equals one in census years after father j first enters office and zero before entry. Matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. The control mean reports the mean of the dependent variable in levels among matched controls in the estimation sample (Mean of Occscore for Column (2) and mean of wage income for Column (7)). Standard errors are clustered at the father level in Columns (1)–(6) and at the matched-pair level in Column (7).
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

Taken together, the evidence for daughters is more limited than for sons. Fathers' officeholding does not increase daughters' labor-force participation or improve their labor-market outcomes on average, although there is suggestive evidence of higher occupational standing among the selected group of daughters who work. Nor do the benefits appear to operate through more advantageous marital matches or improvements in sons-in-law's occupational outcomes. The remainder of the paper therefore focuses on sons, for whom the labor-market effects are more consistently observed and can be examined in greater detail.

4.3 Validity of the Design

The key identification assumption is that in the absence of the fathers' entry into office, the labor market evolution of officials' children should be similar to their matched counterparts. Although this assumption cannot be tested directly, the event-study estimates provide no evidence of differential trends before office entry. I next consider several potential threats to this assumption, including selection into politics, measurement error, reverse causality, and spillovers to the comparison group.

Positive selection into politics. A potential concern is that fathers who enter politics may differ from matched counterparts in unobserved ways that also benefit their children. For example, political ambition, local standing, or preexisting social networks could both increase a father's likelihood of obtaining office and improve his son's labor market outcomes. In that case, the baseline estimates could partly reflect family characteristics before the officeholding rather than the effect of holding office itself.

I address this concern using two complementary comparison groups composed of families whose fathers were also politically active. The first design compares sons of officials who entered office in 1918 with sons of officials who entered shortly afterward in 1922. Because all fathers in this analysis eventually hold office, the groups are likely to be more similar in political ambition, engagement, and local standing than officials and non-officials in the baseline matched sample. The identifying variation comes from the narrow difference in timing that fathers entering in 1918 had already assumed office by the 1920 Census, whereas fathers entering in 1922 had not.

Figure 4 reports the result. There is no evidence of differential pre-treatment trends. By the 1920 Census, sons of officials who entered office in 1918 experience an increase in occupational income score relative to sons of officials who would enter office shortly thereafter. The pattern is consistent with the baseline estimates and suggests that the main findings are not driven solely by persistent differences between politically connected and nonpolitical families.

The second design compares the children of winning and losing candidates. Specifically, I compare the children of the last winner, i.e., the elected candidate receiving the fewest votes, to those of the first loser, i.e., the unelected candidate receiving the most votes, based on the vote returns.[10] Relative to the baseline matched design, this approach narrows the comparison to children whose fathers were actively competing for offices and are therefore likely to be more similar in unobserved ambition, political engagement, and local standing.

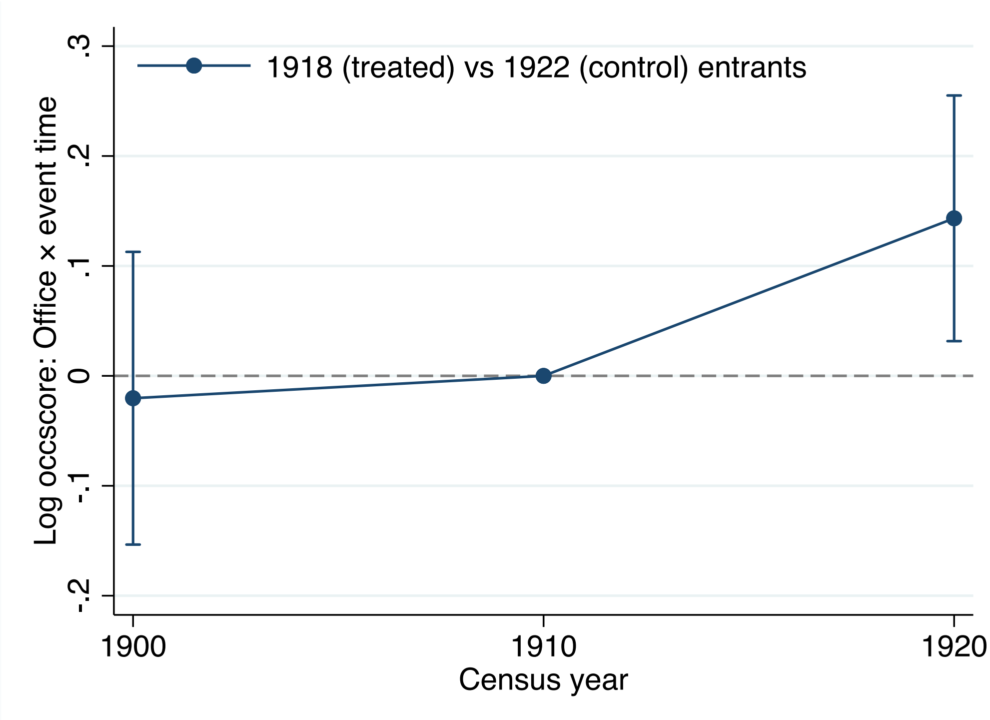


Figure 4. Comparing Children of Current Officials and Future Officials
Note: This figure presents the dynamics of sons' occupational income from estimating Equation 2. The sample includes sons whose fathers first enter local office in 1918 and sons whose fathers first enter office in 1922 from Census 1900 to 1920. Sons of 1918 entrants are the treated group, while sons of 1922 entrants are the future-treated comparison group. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

Figure 5 presents the corresponding event-study plot using a sample consisting of children of the last winning and first losing candidates. Although the estimates are less precise because of the small sample, the post-election pattern is again consistent with the baseline finding that sons of winning candidates tend to have higher occupational income

[10]The ideal design would be a regression discontinuity design. However, because election returns are available for only a limited sample of races recovered from historical newspapers, the sample is too small to implement an RDD.

after fathers' office entry. Taken together, these two complementary designs provide support for the validity of the main results.[11]

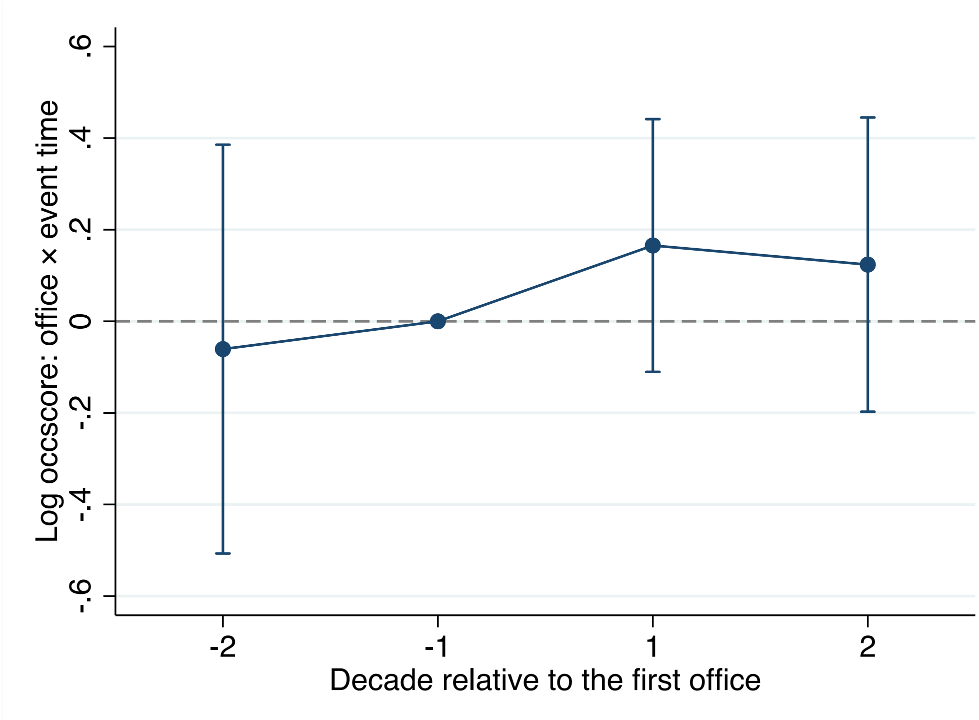


Figure 5. Comparing Children of Last Winning and First Losing Candidates
Note: This figure presents the dynamics of sons' occupational income from estimating Equation 2. The sample includes sons of last winning candidates and first losing candidates in races where information on electoral return is available. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

Measurement error. The information on local officials is collected from *Ohio Rosters of Township and Municipal Officers* between 1912 and 1929. I discuss some potential forms of measurement error that may arise from the construction of these data.

First, because the rosters collected start from 1912, a concern is that the recorded start year may not reflect the true beginning year of officials' officeholding, introducing measurement error in treatment timing. In the main analysis, I exclude officials who were first observed in 1912 to address the left-censoring problem. However, the concern still remains that some officials recorded as starting in 1914 or later may in fact have held office

[11]The estimates from the two complementary designs are somewhat larger in magnitude than the estimate from the main matched difference-in-differences design. The difference might reflect the differences in the sample of these designs. For the winners versus losers design, the sample includes mostly races for city mayors and councilmembers, which are usually positions with higher private returns than the others. The not-yet-treated design compares families that all eventually enter politics but differ in the timing of office entry, and therefore identifies effects within a more politically selected sample. Despite differences in magnitude, the estimates are consistently positive across designs.

prior to 1912 or held the office in non-continuous years. To mitigate this possibility, I redo the analysis restricting the sample to individuals whose fathers are first observed entering office after 1920 and their matched controls, since it is less likely that officials had a gap of more than a decade in their political careers. Table D1 reports these results and gets similar effects of fathers' officeholding.

Second, reporting practices in the rosters vary across jurisdictions and years. In some years, some governments report only the president of the council while omitting the names of council members. This incomplete reporting may misclassify some officeholders as non-officeholders. If omitted officials enter the control group during matching, such misclassification would bias the estimated effects downward. Therefore, the estimates should be interpreted as lower bounds of the true effect of officeholding. To reduce this concern, the matching procedure described in Section 3.1 excludes individuals employed in the public sector in the Census from the pool of potential controls, since unreported local officials are more likely to appear in public-sector occupations.

Finally, errors may arise when linking officials in the rosters to individuals in the Census. The probability of incorrect links is higher when roster information is limited. In particular, some offices report only the initials of officials' first names rather than full names. To assess the sensitivity of the results to potential linking error, Table D4 therefore re-estimates the main specification after excluding officials whose first names are recorded only as initials. The estimates remain similar, providing reassurance that ambiguous name records are not driving the results.

Reverse Causality. Another concern is that the estimated effect might reflect reverse causality that children's success may have helped their fathers obtain office, rather than officeholding improving children's subsequent outcomes. To test this possibility, I restrict the analysis to sons who were relatively young when their fathers entered office. These sons were less likely to possess the occupational standing, resources, or local influence needed to affect their fathers' political careers. Table D2 still shows a positive effect of fathers' officeholding in this sample. The estimate is, if anything, larger among younger sons, which is inconsistent with the results being driven primarily by reverse causality from sons' prior success.

Spillovers from the officials. As discussed in Section 3.1, the matching compares children of officials with children of non-officials. Some comparison children may nevertheless belong to the extended families of local officials and may therefore benefit indirectly from political connections. Such spillovers might attenuate the effect of officeholding. I reconstruct the comparison group after excluding individuals who share a surname with any official in the same county. Table D3 reports estimates similar to the baseline results.

4.4 Robustness

In Appendix E.3, I show that the result is robust using alternative standard errors, measures of outcomes, specifications, and samples.

Alternative Inference. Table E3 shows that the result is robust when the standard errors are clustered at the individual level, matched-pairs level, and county level.

Alternative measures of outcomes and specifications. In Table E4 and Figure E9, I adopt different forms of the dependent variable (level, log, and LIDO score obtained from Saavedra and Twinam (2020) described in Section 2.4) and pseudo Poisson maximum likelihood estimation for the non-negative nature of the dependent variable (Silva and Tenreyro, 2006). All results show a positive effect of fathers' officeholding on sons' occupational income.

Alternative samples. Table E5 and Figure E10 show that the result is robust using a balanced panel, using only the sample of sons whose fathers started the office between 1914 and 1920 and their matched counterparts, and using only the sample of sons whose fathers started the office between 1920 and 1928 and their matched counterparts. Figure E11 shows that the result is robust to the exclusion of any county in Ohio.

5 How Does Officeholding Improve Occupational Outcomes?

This section explores how fathers' local officeholding improves sons' occupational outcomes. To clarify, because the analysis focuses on sons who were already of working age before their fathers entered office, changes in childhood investments or completed schooling are unlikely to explain the main results. I therefore focus on whether officeholding expands sons' access to employment opportunities.

Two channels are especially plausible. First, local officials may help their sons obtain public-sector jobs through appointment authority, recommendations, or other forms of political influence over hiring. Second, firms may offer better private-sector opportunities to officials' sons because employing politically connected employees can facilitate access to local governments or other potential resources. I use the term preferential access to encompass these forms of politically mediated advantage. In Section 5.3, I discuss some other potential explanations.

5.1 Favoritism in the Public Sector

Politicians often have discretion over hiring decisions in the public sector. Hence, public employment could often be allocated through patronage and political recommendations rather than exclusively through formal merit-based recruitment. This was especially true in the United States before the widespread adoption of civil service reforms, when American politics operated largely under a patronage system (Wilson, 1961). Politicians could allocate government positions based on personal loyalty or family ties rather than merit. If local officials could influence hiring in the public sector, their children might gain preferential access to public-sector jobs. I use favoritism broadly to refer to such preferential access, which may operate through channels such as direct appointment and political recommendations.

If local officials helped their sons obtain public-sector jobs, the resulting employment gains should be concentrated in positions where local political influence could plausibly matter and should be weaker where formal hiring rules constrained officials' discretion. I examine these implications using variation across types of public employment, government institutions, and the adoption of municipal civil-service reform.

Historical newspapers provide direct examples of such practices. Figure A4 and A5 present one example from Ohio, where a newspaper reports that the mayor in Dayton appointed his son as chief clerk, replacing the incumbent employee. Such examples do not establish how widespread direct appointments were, but they illustrate how officeholding could provide preferential access to public employment. This section provides more evidence consistent with this mechanism.

I begin by examining whether fathers' officeholding increases sons' probability of getting employed in the public sector. Column (1) in Table 5 and Panel A in Figure 6 show a sizable and statistically significant increase in the probability that sons work in the public sector after fathers enter office. On average, fathers' entry into office increases their sons' probability of getting employed in the public sector by 1.2 percentage points, roughly 70% of the control mean. This increase appears immediately in the first census after fathers start the office and persists for nearly two decades, indicating that access to public employment is an important channel through which local officeholding generates intergenerational benefits.

To assess whether this increase reflects favoritism in public-sector hiring, I examine three complementary sources of variation in the scope for local political influence. First, I compare effects across types of public-sector jobs, distinguishing positions connected to local appointment authority or political recommendation networks from those less direct to local influence. Second, I compare city, village, and township governments, which differed in the extent to which public-sector recruitment was constrained by formal civil-service rules. Third, within cities, I exploit the staggered adoption of municipal civil-service reform to examine whether formal restrictions on discretionary hiring attenuated the benefits of fathers' officeholding.

First, I examine variation across types of public-sector jobs. If fathers' political positions facilitated access to government jobs, the gains should be concentrated in positions in which local appointment authority or political recommendation networks matter more. Columns (2) to (5) in Table 5 disaggregate public employment by government type. The increase in sons' public-sector employment is concentrated in local government and the postal service, while there is no corresponding increase in state or federal employment, which lies largely outside local discretion.[12] This pattern is consistent with preferential access operating through local hiring discretion and political recommendation networks, rather than a general increase in sons' government employment.

Second, I exploit institutional differences in hiring discretion across government formats. During the Progressive Era, many Ohio cities adopted civil service systems aimed at curbing patronage and formalizing recruitment, following the 1902 Ohio Civil Service Act. In contrast, villages and townships typically operated under weaker or non civil service mandates, granting local officials substantially greater discretion over public-sector hiring. Consistent with this institutional distinction, Columns (1) to (3) in Table 6 show that fathers' officeholding significantly increases sons' public-sector employment in village and township governments, while the effect for city governments employment is much smaller and noisier. This heterogeneity aligns with the idea that civil

[12]One may wonder why local officeholding increases sons' employment in the postal service, given that postal jobs were federally administered and the Pendleton Act in 1883 curtailed patronage in part of the federal bureaucracy. Although local officials did not control federal hiring, postal employment remained tied to political recommendation networks (Johnson and Libecap, 1994). In addition, the federal civil service reform was gradual and incomplete, starting with larger offices and more urban offices, which left smaller local offices less impacted (Aneja and Xu, 2024).

service rules limit discretionary hiring and reduce officials' ability to facilitate public employment for their sons.

I then examine which sons are more likely to enter the public sector following their fathers' officeholding. Columns (4) and (5) in Table 6 split the sample by sons' pre-office occupational income. The increase in public-sector employment is concentrated among sons with lower pre-office occupational income relative to the public-sector mean. Officeholding therefore appears to expand access most strongly for sons who began in relatively less advantaged occupations. This finding helps characterize the incidence of the public-sector benefit. The increase is not driven primarily by already successful sons moving into government employment.

The comparisons across government formats provide suggestive evidence that hiring institutions matter, but cities, villages, and townships may differ along many other dimensions. I therefore turn to the staggered adoption of municipal civil-service reform within Ohio cities, which provides a more direct test of whether formal recruitment constraints weakened the intergenerational benefits of officeholding.

Table 5. Impact on Getting Jobs in the Public Sector

	Aggregate	Category			
	(1) Public sector	(2) Postal service	(3) Local government	(4) State government	(5) Federal government
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.0115***	0.0067***	0.0041***	0.0003	0.0008
	(0.0022)	(0.0014)	(0.0015)	(0.0003)	(0.0007)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	0.0173	0.0068	0.0081	0.0003	0.0020
R^2	0.5083	0.5767	0.4149	0.3043	0.3641
Observations	88251	88251	88251	88251	88251

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on the probability of getting a job in the public sector. The dependent variable for Column (1) is a dummy equal to one if the individual is employed in the public sector and zero otherwise. Columns (2) to (5) disaggregate the public sector into four categories: postal service (Column (2)), local governments (Column (3)), State government (Column (4)), and Federal government (Column (5)). The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.

Table 6. Heterogeneity on Getting Jobs in the Public Sector

	Dependent variable: Public-sector employment				
	Government Format			Pre-office Occscore	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	City	Village	Township	Low income	High income
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.0029	0.0095***	0.0141***	0.0126***	0.0070
	(0.0092)	(0.0036)	(0.0029)	(0.0023)	(0.0066)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	0.0220	0.0196	0.0156	0.0140	0.0362
R^2	0.5135	0.5186	0.5036	0.4855	0.5525
Observations	5684	31900	50667	70387	14377

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on the probability of getting a job in the public sector across different samples. The dependent variables are dummy variables equal to one if the individual is employed in the public sector and zero otherwise. Columns (1) to (3) separate the sample by the format of governments: city governments, village governments, and township governments. Columns (4) and (5) separate the sample by sons' occupational income at $t = -1$. Specifically, the sample in Column (4) includes sons with occupational income lower than the mean occupational income earned in the public sector and their matched counterparts while the sample in Column (5) includes son with higher occupational income than the average public sector occupational income and their matched counterparts. The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.

Civil-service systems formalized public-sector recruitment and limited politicians' influence over appointments. If favoritism in public-sector hiring contributes to the effects documented above, the benefits of fathers' officeholding should be weaker when fathers enter office under a civil-service system. I use data from Kuipers and Sahn (2023) on the timing of municipal civil-service adoption. Figure A3 plots the distribution of reform timing across municipalities in Ohio.

I exploit the staggered adoption of municipal civil-service systems across Ohio cities to compare the intergenerational returns to officeholding for fathers who enter office before versus after their city adopts civil service. Specifically, I estimate a triple-differences specification that interacts fathers' officeholding, post-office dummy, and the civil-service adoption in city when the father first enters office. The coefficient on the triple interaction captures whether the effect of fathers' officeholding differs when office entry occurs under a civil-service system. The specification is as follows:

$$
\begin{aligned}
y_{ibct} = \alpha_i + &\beta_1 \text{Reform}_{j(i)} \times \text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it} + \beta_2(\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}) + \beta_3 \text{Reform}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it} \\
&+ \beta_4 \text{Post}_{it} + \theta_{bt} + \mu_c + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{ibct}
\end{aligned}
\tag{3}
$$

where $\text{Reform}_{j(i)}$ is a binary variable equal to one if the city in which father j holds office had already adopted a civil-service system at the time of his office entry, and zero otherwise. Reform status is therefore fixed for each treated father and is assigned to the matched control. Because civil service reforms were more likely to be adopted earlier in larger cities (Kuipers and Sahn, 2023), where labor market conditions may differ systematically, I additionally control for interactions between city population size, measured by log population in 1930 Census, and $\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$, addressing the concern of $\text{Reform}_{j(i)} \times \text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$ capturing such effect of city size.

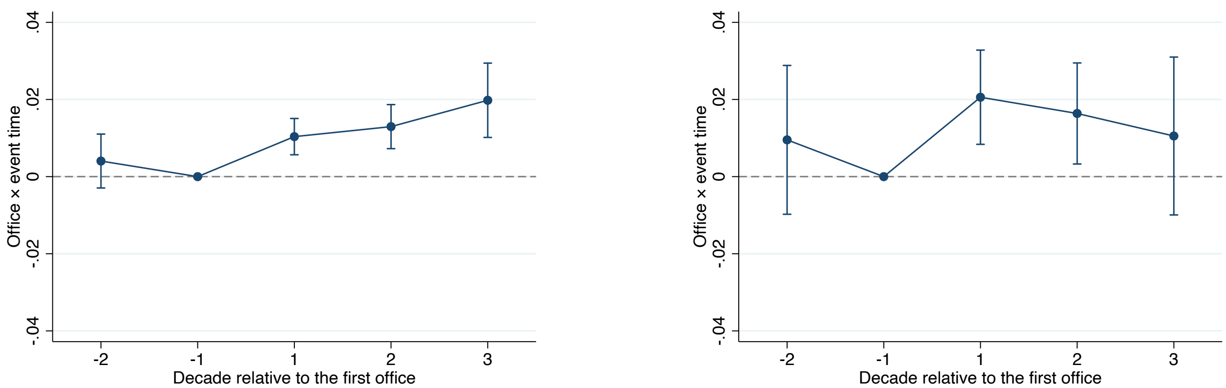
Table 7. Impact by Civil Service Reform Status

	Logged Income Score$_{it}$		Goverment Job$_{it}$		Private White-collar$_{it}$		Private Blue-collar$_{it}$	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
$\text{Reform}_{j(i)} \times \text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	-0.114*	-0.114*	-0.030	-0.031	0.137*	0.138**	-0.012	-0.013
	(0.066)	(0.066)	(0.029)	(0.029)	(0.070)	(0.070)	(0.065)	(0.065)
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.136**	0.139**	0.030	0.023	-0.081	-0.062	0.025	0.018
	(0.064)	(0.064)	(0.027)	(0.027)	(0.065)	(0.066)	(0.060)	(0.060)
$\text{Population}_{j(i)} \times \text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$		-0.001		0.001		-0.004**		0.001
		(0.001)		(0.001)		(0.001)		(0.001)
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	29.793	29.793	0.026	0.026	0.403	0.403	0.313	0.313
R^2	0.739	0.739	0.556	0.557	0.690	0.691	0.613	0.613
Observations	5925	5925	6245	6245	6245	6245	6245	6245

Note: This table reports regression results of triple differences estimated using Equation 3. The dependent variables are log occupational income score (Columns (1)-(2)), whether employed in the public sector (Columns (3)-(4)), whether employed in the private-sector white-collar jobs (Columns (5)-(6)), and whether employed in the private-sector blue-collar jobs (Columns (7)-(8)). The sample includes sons of officials in the city governments and their matched counterparts. The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. Reform is a binary variable equal to 1 if individual's father starts the office when the city has already adopted the civil service reform and equal to 0 otherwise. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.

Table 7 reports the results. Columns (1) and (2) show that the occupational income gain associated with fathers' officeholding is substantially smaller among fathers who enter office after their city has adopted civil service. This pattern is consistent with institutional constraints in public-sector hiring reducing the occupational advantages that officials can transmit to their sons.

Columns (3) and (4) examine the public employment channel directly. The triple-differences estimate is negative, suggesting that civil-service reform weakens the public-sector employment gains of officials' sons, although it is imprecisely estimated. Columns (5) and (6) show a different pattern for private-sector white-collar employment. While there is little evidence of a private-sector white-collar advantage among fathers entering office before civil-service adoption, the effect becomes substantially larger for fathers entering office under a civil-service system. One possible interpretation is that when formal hiring rules restrict officials' ability to facilitate public employment, political advantage shifts toward private-sector opportunities. Columns (7) and (8) provide a placebo test and show no comparable pattern for private-sector blue-collar employment. This contrast suggests that the post-reform increase is specific to white-collar opportunities rather than reflecting a general improvement in sons' private-sector employment.



A. Government Jobs

B. Private-sector White-collar Jobs

Figure 6. Dynamic Effects of Fathers' Officeholding on Jobs

Note: This figure reports event-study estimates of the effect of fathers' local officeholding on sons' employment outcomes from Equation 2 Panel A examines employment in the public sector, and Panel B examines employment in a white-collar job in the private sector. The solid dots report point estimates, and the bars show 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered at the father level.

Taken together, the evidence is consistent with favoritism in public-sector employment contributing to the intergenerational effects of local officeholding. Sons' public-sector gains are concentrated in local-government and postal employment, are larger in institutional settings with weaker hiring constraints, and are strongest among sons who began in less advantaged occupations. The staggered civil-service analysis further shows that when the civil service reform limits discretionary hiring, the intergenerational political advantages are substantially attenuated and appear to shift toward private-sector white-collar employment.

Other channels, such as changes in preferences, role-model effects, or general information about labor-market opportunities, may also have contributed to officials' sons' occupational gains. However, the three pieces of evidence from public-sector employment are difficult to explain solely through these alternative channels. Together, they suggest that fathers' political positions expanded sons' access to public employment through appointment authority, recommendations, and related forms of local political influence. Because the evidence cannot distinguish cleanly among these practices, I interpret the results as evidence of favoritism broadly defined rather than of direct nepotistic appointment alone.

5.2 Better Opportunities in the Private Sector

Fathers' officeholding may also improve sons' opportunities outside the public sector. Local governments interact with firms through licensing, zoning, procurement, taxation, and other administrative decisions. These interactions may make politically connected workers valuable to private employers, whether because they facilitate access to officials, provide information about local government, or signal useful political relationships. This section examines whether fathers' officeholding increases sons' access to private-sector white-collar employment and whether the effects are concentrated in settings where political connections are more likely to matter.

Column (1) of Table 8 and Panel B of Figure 6 show that sons of officials are more likely to be employed in private-sector white-collar jobs after their fathers take office, indicating that the occupational benefits of officeholding are not confined to government jobs.

Columns (2) to (4) examine how the effect varies across government formats. The increase in private-sector white-collar employment is largest in cities, smaller in villages, and statistically indistinguishable from zero in townships. This pattern is consistent with the distribution of private-sector opportunities, as cities have more firms and denser business activities hence more interactions between local governments and businesses.

Figure 7 further disaggregates private-sector white-collar employment by industry. The increase is concentrated in wholesale and retail trade and in finance, insurance, and real estate. These sectors relied heavily on local commercial relationships and were potentially sensitive to municipal regulation such as licensing and zoning, property decisions, and access to local information. The concentration of the effects in these industries is therefore consistent with firms placing value on workers connected to local political authority.

Taken together, the results suggest that private-sector white-collar employment is an additional margin through which fathers' officeholding benefits sons. The evidence is consistent with political connections improving sons' access to firms and sectors in which relationships with local government are especially valuable. However, it is hard to distinguish whether these gains arise from employer demand for politically connected workers, referrals and recommendations by officials, or broader political and social networks. I therefore interpret the findings as evidence consistent with generally politically mediated access to private-sector opportunities.

Table 8. Impact on Getting White-collar Jobs in the Private Sector

	Aggregate	Government Format		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
	Private sector	City	Village	Township
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.0159***	0.0581**	0.0225**	0.0054
	(0.0054)	(0.0249)	(0.0094)	(0.0065)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	0.1887	0.3745	0.2375	0.1429
R^2	0.6361	0.6167	0.6312	0.6269
Observations	88251	5684	31900	50667

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of fathers' officeholding on the probability of getting a white-collar job in the private sector. The dependent variables are dummy variables equal to one if the individual is employed in a white-collar job in the private sector and zero otherwise. Column (1) includes the full sample of matched sons who had reached working age in the pre-office census in Censuses 1900 to 1940. Columns (2) to (4) separate the sample by the format of governments: city governments, village governments, and township governments. The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.

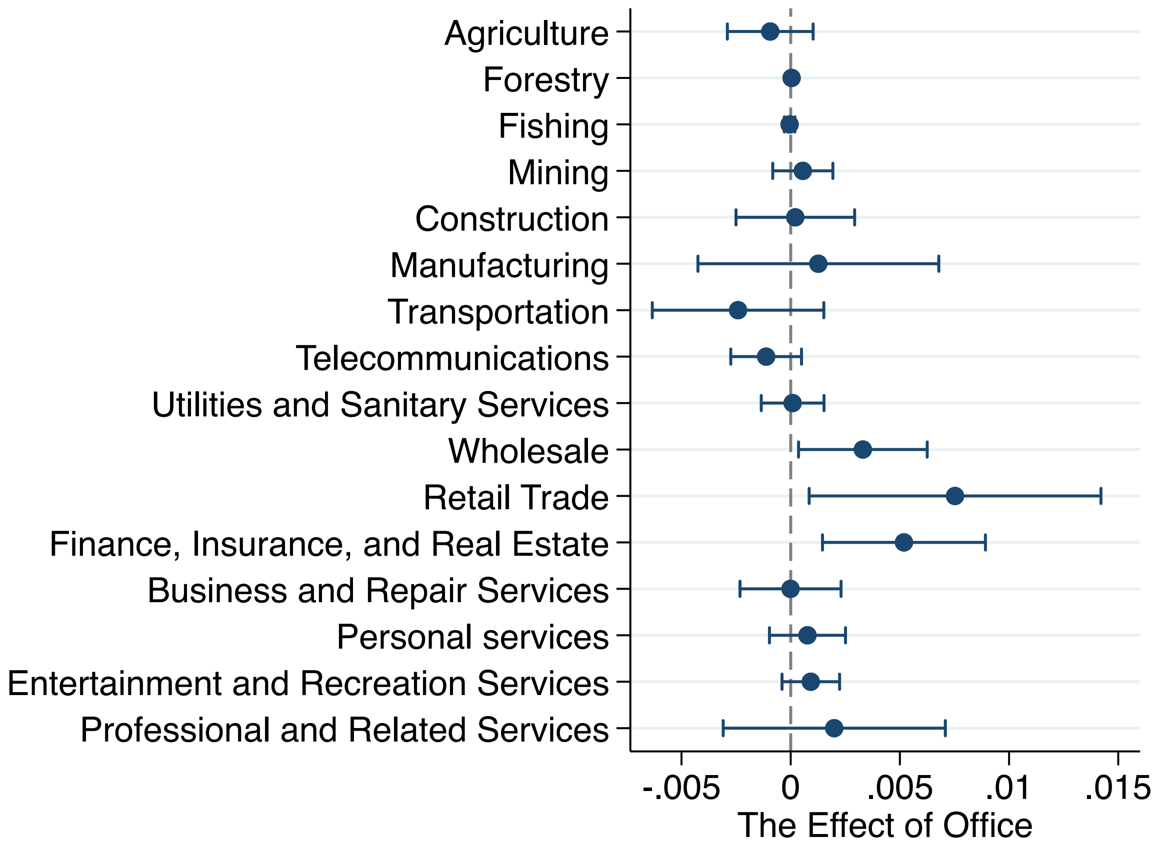


Figure 7. Heterogeneity of Private-sector White-collar Jobs

Note: This figure plots the coefficient of Office × Post on the probability of getting employed in white-collar jobs in the private sector by industries. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

5.3 Other Mechanisms

This section examines alternative mechanisms through which fathers' officeholding increases sons' occupational income.

One potential explanation is occupational inheritance, whereby sons take over their fathers' pre-office jobs after fathers' office entry. This channel is unlikely for two reasons. First, many local offices during this period were not full-time positions and did not require officials to leave their previous employment (Ohio, 1910). Second, Table F1 directly tests whether sons are more likely to enter their fathers' pre-office occupations and shows no evidence consistent with this mechanism.

Another possibility is social-network expansion. Fathers' officeholding may broaden families' access to social and professional networks, which could indirectly improve sons' labor market prospects. While social networks are difficult to measure, Table F2 partially explores this channel by examining whether fathers' officeholding affects sons' marriage networks. Table F2 shows no evidence that sons of officials are more likely to marry spouses from wealthier families, from families with fathers employed in the public sector, or from families in white-collar occupations. These results suggest limited scope for marriage-based network expansion as a driver of the observed occupational gains.

Finally, the observed advantage could reflect a reputational effect, whereby sons benefit from the prestige or visibility associated with their fathers' political status. If reputation operates primarily through name recognition, its effects should be stronger for sons with less common surnames, whose family identity is more easily identifiable. Table F3 tests this implication and finds no significant heterogeneity by surname commonness for sons' occupational income score. There is some suggestive evidence that officials' sons with rare surnames have higher probability of being employed in private-sector white-collar jobs.

6 Exploring Potential Downstream Effects

So far, the paper documents that fathers' local officeholding improves sons' access to public-sector employment and private-sector white-collar occupations. Beyond the officials' families, these gains may also have broader consequences for the allocation of economic opportunities within local communities. Such consequences may be particularly relevant in small jurisdictions, where public-sector positions and other desirable jobs are relatively scarce. This section explores whether localities with greater exposure to officials' sons in public employment subsequently exhibit different patterns of income inequality.

The analysis in this section is exploratory. Officials' sons are not exogenously assigned to public-sector jobs or across localities, and their presence may be correlated with persistent political, institutional, or economic characteristics. The estimates should therefore be interpreted as suggestive rather than as causal effects of intergenerational political advantage.

Measuring Local Exposure. To measure locality-level exposure to intergenerational political advantage, I construct a proxy based on the share of public-sector employees residing in a locality who are sons of local officials, as observed in the 1930 Census. I identify individuals' residential localities in the Census using place linkages from Berkes et al. (2023). Note that this measure is based on the son's place of residence rather than the jurisdiction in which his father held office. I therefore do not require an official's son to reside in the same locality where his father served. This choice reflects limitations in consistently mapping locality names in the official rosters to Census place identifiers that locality names are not always recorded consistently across the two sources, making a systematic same-jurisdiction match difficult. The measure should therefore be interpreted as capturing the local concentration of individuals from politically connected families in public employment, rather than the share of public employees directly connected to officials serving in that particular locality. I focus on townships and cities. Matching villages across the rosters and Census place data is particularly difficult because village names are often shared with cities or townships within the same county. Requiring an unambiguous match between roster and Census locality names would leave only around 20 villages, which is too small for a meaningful locality-level analysis. I therefore exclude villages from this exercise. For townships and cities, I further exclude places whose names overlap within the same county to reduce ambiguity in assigning Census observations to locality type. This procedure yields a matched sample of 967 townships and 60 cities.

In some townships, the number of public-sector employees observed in the Census is very small, causing the exposure share to take mechanically extreme values.[13] I therefore restrict the baseline analysis to localities with at least five observed public-sector employees. This makes the measure more interpretable as a feature of local public-sector composition rather than an artifact of a very small denominator. I also control for the public-employment share of the local population to account for differences in local government size. Appendix Section G shows consistent results when using the full sample and alternative thresholds for the number of public employees.

Figure A6 plots the distribution of the locality-level exposure measure, the share of public employees who are sons of local officials, separately for townships and cities. In both types of localities, the distribution is highly concentrated near zero, indicating that officials' sons generally account for only a small fraction of the local public-sector workforce. The city distribution is particularly concentrated at very low values, while townships exhibit greater dispersion and a longer right tail. Overall, the figure shows that exposure is typically limited but varies more substantially across townships than across cities. In the analysis, I use both measures of (i) a binary indicator for whether a locality employs at least one official's son in the public sector and (ii) a continuous measure equal to the share of public employees who are sons of local officials.

[13] For example, if only two public employees are observed, the presence of one official's son generates an exposure share of one-half.

Table 9. Exposure to Intergenerational Political Advantages and Subsequent Income Inequality.

	Township				City			
	(1) Gini	(2) Gini	(3) Top-10% Share	(4) Top-10% Share	(5) Gini	(6) Gini	(7) Top-10% Share	(8) Top-10% Share
Share of politicians' sons in pub (sd)	0.016***		0.013***		-0.001		0.002	
	(0.006)		(0.005)		(0.002)		(0.002)	
Sons in pub		0.020***		0.020***		-0.007		0.004
		(0.007)		(0.006)		(0.012)		(0.011)
Controls	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Dependent Mean	0.578	0.578	0.343	0.343	0.455	0.455	0.271	0.271
R^2	0.658	0.658	0.609	0.612	0.618	0.621	0.487	0.487
Observations	469	469	469	469	60	60	60	60

Note: This table reports locality-level regressions of income inequality in 1940 on exposure to officials' sons in public employment in 1930. The sample includes cities and townships with public employees size larger than 5. Columns (1)–(4) use the township sample, and Columns (5)–(8) use the city sample. The dependent variables are the Gini coefficient in Columns (1), (2), (5), and (6), and the share of wage income accruing to the top 10 percent of workers in Columns (3), (4), (7), and (8). *Share of officials' sons in pub (sd)* is the standardized share of public-sector employees who are sons of local officials. *Sons in pub* is a binary variable equal to one if at least one public-sector employee residing in the locality is the son of a local official. All specifications control for the male, white, native-born, urban, employment, agricultural-employment, and public-employment shares, log population, and the 1930 Gini coefficient constructed from occupational income scores. Standard errors are clustered at the county level.

Table 9 examines whether the local concentration of officials' sons in public employment is associated with broader differences in the distribution of income. The analysis is conditional on locality characteristics including the male, white, native-born, urban, employed, agricultural-employment, and public-employment shares, as well as log population. I also control for pre-existing inequality using the 1930 Gini coefficient constructed from occupational income scores. Because individual wage income is not available in the 1930 Census, this measure is an occupation-based proxy for baseline inequality. The estimates therefore compare localities with similar observed demographic composition, economic structure, public-sector size, population, and initial inequality, rather than capturing unconditional differences across localities.

Columns (1) – (4) report the results for townships. Greater exposure to officials' sons in public employment is associated with higher income inequality in 1940. A one-standard-deviation increase in their share among public employees is associated with a 0.016 increase in the Gini coefficient and a 1.3-percentage-point increase in the share of income accruing to the top decile. When exposure is measured using the binary indicator, the presence of at least one such employee is associated with an approximately 0.02 increase in the Gini coefficient and a 2.0-percentage-point increase in the top-decile income share. These relationships are estimated conditional on township demographic and economic characteristics and the corresponding Gini coefficient in 1930. The estimates therefore do not simply reflect persistent differences in pre-existing inequality or observable township composition. To provide a sense of magnitude, the estimate in Column (4) corresponds to a 2.0-percentage-point increase in the top-decile income share. Relative to the sample mean of 34.3 percent, this represents an increase of approximately 5.8 percent in earnings accruing to the top-decile.

Columns (5) – (8) report the corresponding estimates for cities. In contrast to the township results, neither the continuous exposure measure nor the binary measure for employing at least one official's son is significantly associated with the Gini coefficient or the top-decile income share. The point estimates are also small and close to zero.

Table G1 and Table G2 show a consistent result using the full sample and using samples of localities with at least ten public sector employees observed.

The township results provide suggestive evidence of a potential distributional cost of intergenerational political advantage. One possible interpretation is that advantages associated with political connections are more consequential in thinner labor markets, where public-sector and other higher-paying opportunities are relatively scarce. In such settings, a greater presence of politically connected workers in public employment may be associated with a more unequal allocation of economic opportunities. By contrast, in cities, larger and more diversified labor markets may make the presence of a relatively small number of such workers less consequential for the overall income distribution.

7 Concluding Remarks

This paper studies how local political power affects the economic opportunities of officials' children. I build a new dataset by digitizing records of township, village, and city officials in early twentieth-century Ohio and linking them to full-count U.S. censuses to follow their children over much of their working lives. Using a matched difference-in-differences design, I find that fathers' entry into local office improves sons' occupational outcomes, with these gains persisting for decades. The effects for daughters are considerably more limited in this context of low female labor force participation. Because the children in the analysis had already reached working age before their fathers entered office, these results show that changes in a parent's political position can alter the labor-market trajectories of adult children, rather than operating primarily through childhood investments in human capital.

The evidence points to access to employment as an important source of these gains. Fathers' officeholding increases sons' employment in the public sector, particularly in local government, and these gains are larger in villages and townships, where public-sector hiring was less constrained by formal civil-service rules. Political advantage also extends beyond government employment. Officials' sons are more likely to enter private-sector white-collar occupations, especially in cities and in sectors where relationships with local government are likely to be more valuable. The civil-service results further suggest that institutions governing public hiring shape how these advantages are transmitted. Occupational gains are substantially smaller when fathers enter office under civil-service systems, while private-sector white-collar gains are larger. Formal constraints on discretion can therefore limit an important channel of political advantage without necessarily eliminating the advantages associated with political connections altogether.

These findings broaden the way we think about the private returns to political power. The officials studied here were not national politicians or entrenched political elites. Many held relatively modest local offices, especially in villages and townships, and came from occupational and family backgrounds close to the middle of the local distribution. Yet acquiring these offices generated long-run economic advantages for their adult children. Political power can therefore contribute to the intergenerational transmission of advantage not only through the persistence of political dynasties, but also by shaping who gains access to economic opportunities outside politics.

The exploratory locality-level evidence points to a possible broader consequence of this process. Townships with greater shares of officials' sons in public employment subsequently exhibit higher income inequality, whereas I find no comparable relationship in cities. These estimates are not causal, but the contrast is consistent with political connections being more consequential in thinner labor markets, where public-sector and other high-paying opportunities are relatively scarce. More generally, the results suggest that the distributional consequences of political connections may depend not only on whether preferential access exists, but also on the institutions and labor markets in which it operates.

I conclude this paper by noting several limitations. First, I focus on a historical setting in which labor markets and gender roles differed substantially from those today, and caution is therefore warranted in extrapolating the magnitudes to contemporary contexts. Second, the available data cannot fully distinguish among direct appointments, political recommendations, employer demand for connected workers, and other ways in which political connections facilitate access to employment. Third, the downstream analysis is descriptive and should therefore be interpreted as suggestive rather than causal. These limitations leave important questions for future work, including how intergenerational political advantage affects public-sector performance, firm behavior, and the allocation of economic resources.

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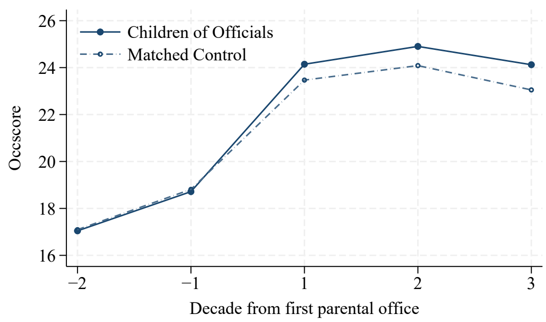
Online Appendices

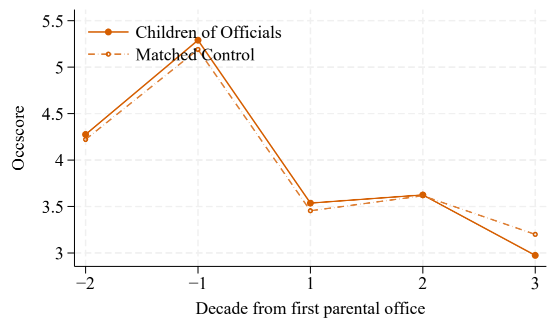
Contents

A Additional Figures

Figure A1. Occupational Income Trends in the Matched Sample

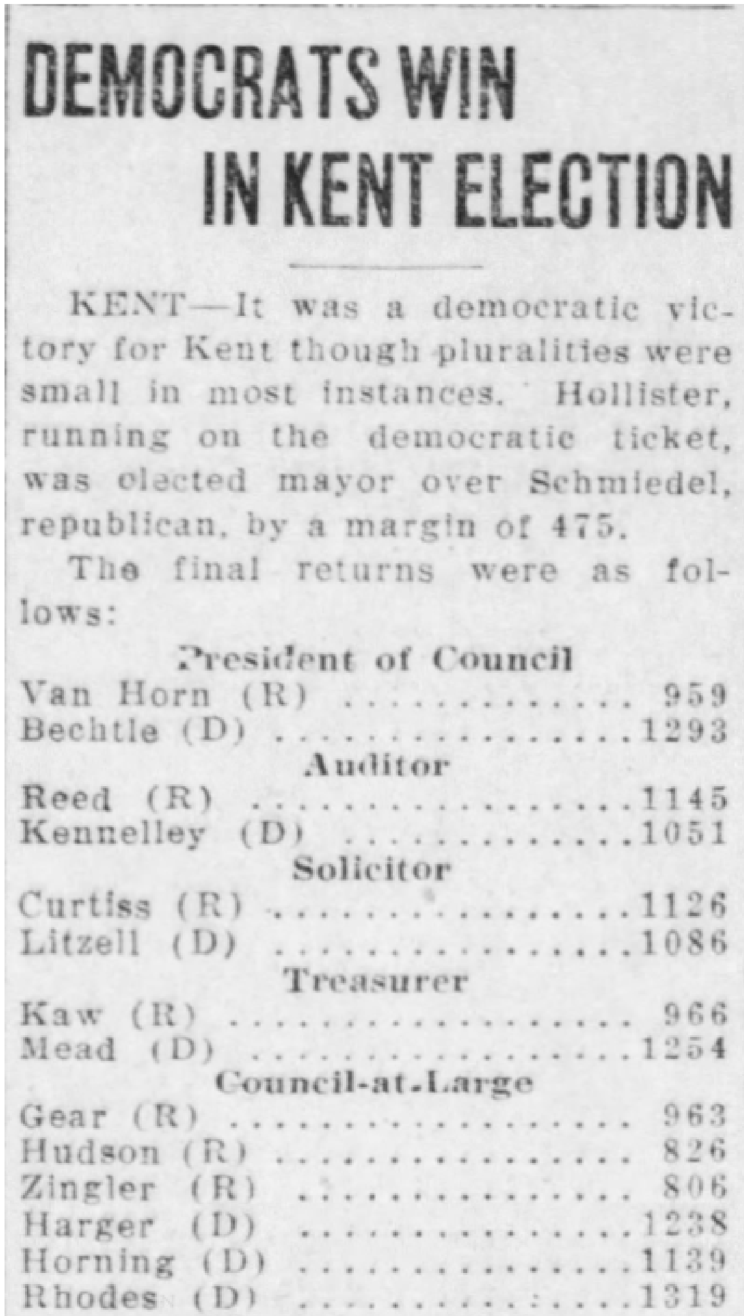


A. Sons



B. Daughters

Note: This figure plots the raw mean occupational income score (OCCSCORE) of officials' children and their matched controls by census wave relative to fathers' first entry into local office. Panel A reports the comparison for sons, and Panel B reports the comparison for daughters. Matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts.



DEMOCRATS WIN IN KENT ELECTION

KENT—It was a democratic victory for Kent though pluralities were small in most instances. Hollister, running on the democratic ticket, was elected mayor over Schmiedel, republican, by a margin of 475.

The final returns were as follows:

President of Council

Van Horn (R)	959
Bechtle (D)	1293

Auditor

Reed (R)	1145
Kennelley (D)	1051

Solicitor

Curtiss (R)	1126
Litzell (D)	1086

Treasurer

Kaw (R)	966
Mead (D)	1254

Council-at-Large

Gear (R)	963
Hudson (R)	826
Zingler (R)	806
Harger (D)	1238
Horning (D)	1139
Rhodes (D)	1319

Figure A2. Example: Newspaper Coverage on Election

Note: This figure presents an example of historical newspaper coverage used to collect local election returns. The newspaper reports candidates' last names, offices, and vote totals, which I use to identify both winning and losing candidates for the electoral comparison. Specifically, I use the last name to search any other newspaper coverage to get information on the candidates' first names to match to Censuses. Source: The Akron Beacon Journal, November 9, 1921, accessed via Newspapers.com.

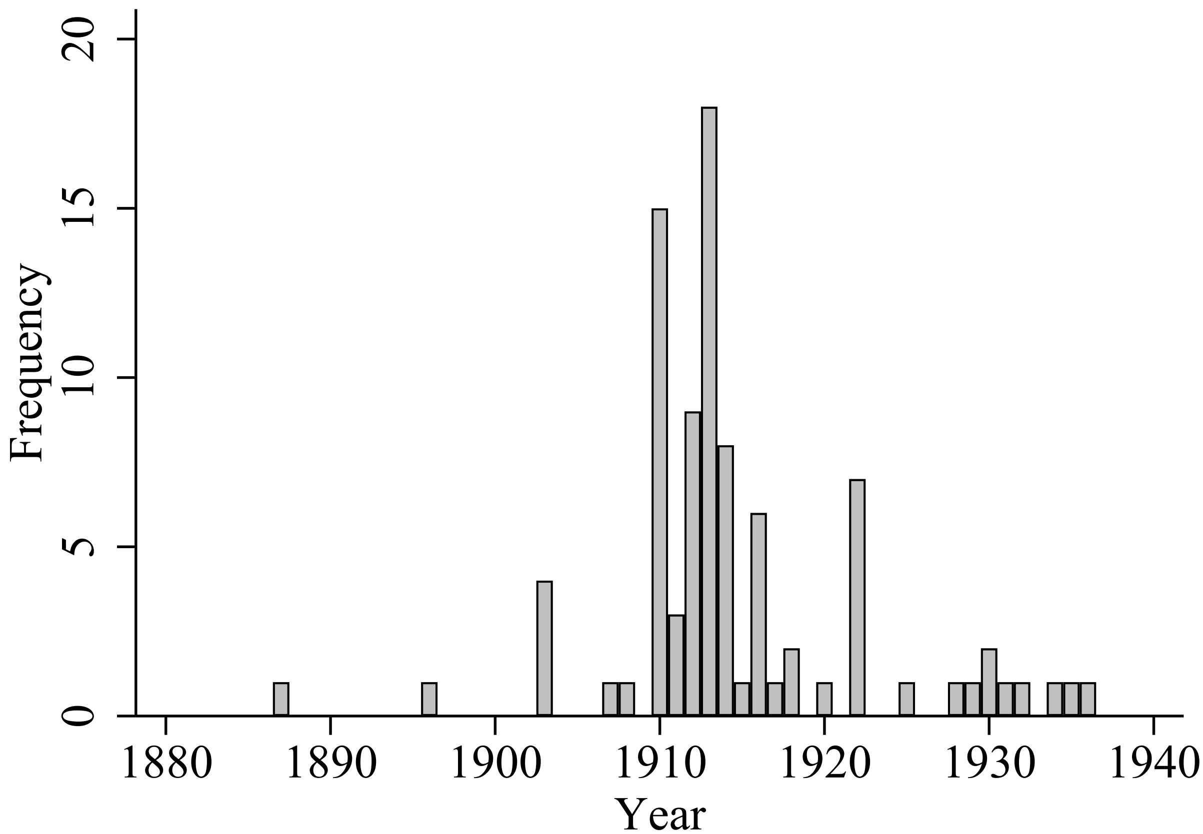
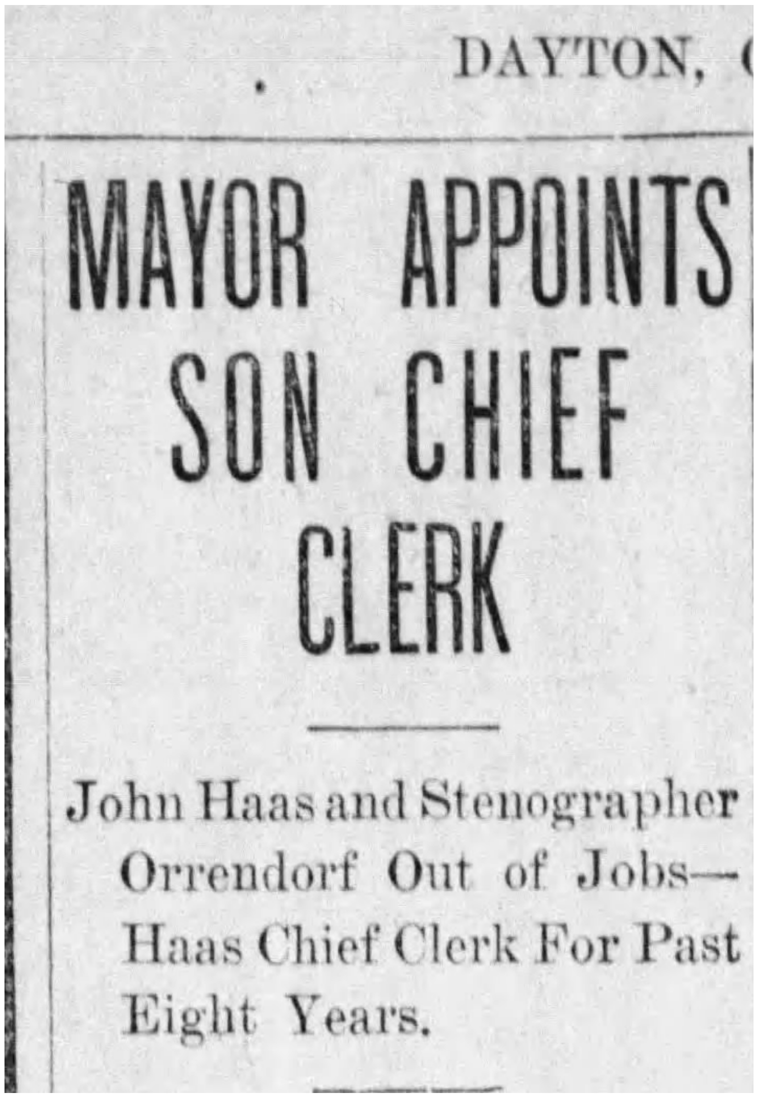


Figure A3. Adoption of Civil Service Reform in Ohio Municipalities

Note: This figure plots the distribution of civil-service reform adoption years across Ohio municipalities. Each bar reports the number of municipalities (including both cities and villages) adopting a civil-service system in the corresponding year. Reform timing is obtained from Kuipers and Sahn (2023).



DAYTON, (

MAYOR APPOINTS SON CHIEF CLERK

John Haas and Stenographer Orrendorf Out of Jobs—Haas Chief Clerk For Past Eight Years.

Figure A4. Clipping from *The Dayton Herald*, October 30, 1906, p. 9, via Newspapers.com

WILL REMAIN IN OFFICE A MONTH

Mayor Calvin D. Wright late Monday afternoon appointed as his chief clerk, his son, William B. Wright, to succeed John A. Haas. E. L. Orrendorf, Mayor Snyder's stenographer, has been notified that his services will no longer be needed. He will leave the employ of the city Wednesday.

The chief clerkship pays $1,500, while the stenographer gets $900. John Haas has been in the Mayor's office since 1898, having served under Mayor Lindemuth and Mayor Snyder. John is widely known in the city, and it is with extreme regret that his friends see him leave public office. His jovial disposition and pleasant ways have made him a favorite in the City Hall, and Republicans and Democrats alike, regret to see him go.

The new clerk, William B. Wright, is 32 years old and lives on Maple street. He has been connected with the National Cash Register Company for seven years, where he worked himself up to a responsible position in the treasurer's office. He is well fitted for the position he will assume.

Mr. Haas will probably remain in the office for a month until the new clerk becomes familiar with the duties.

Figure A5. Clipping from *The Dayton Herald*, October 30, 1906, p. 9, via Newspapers.com

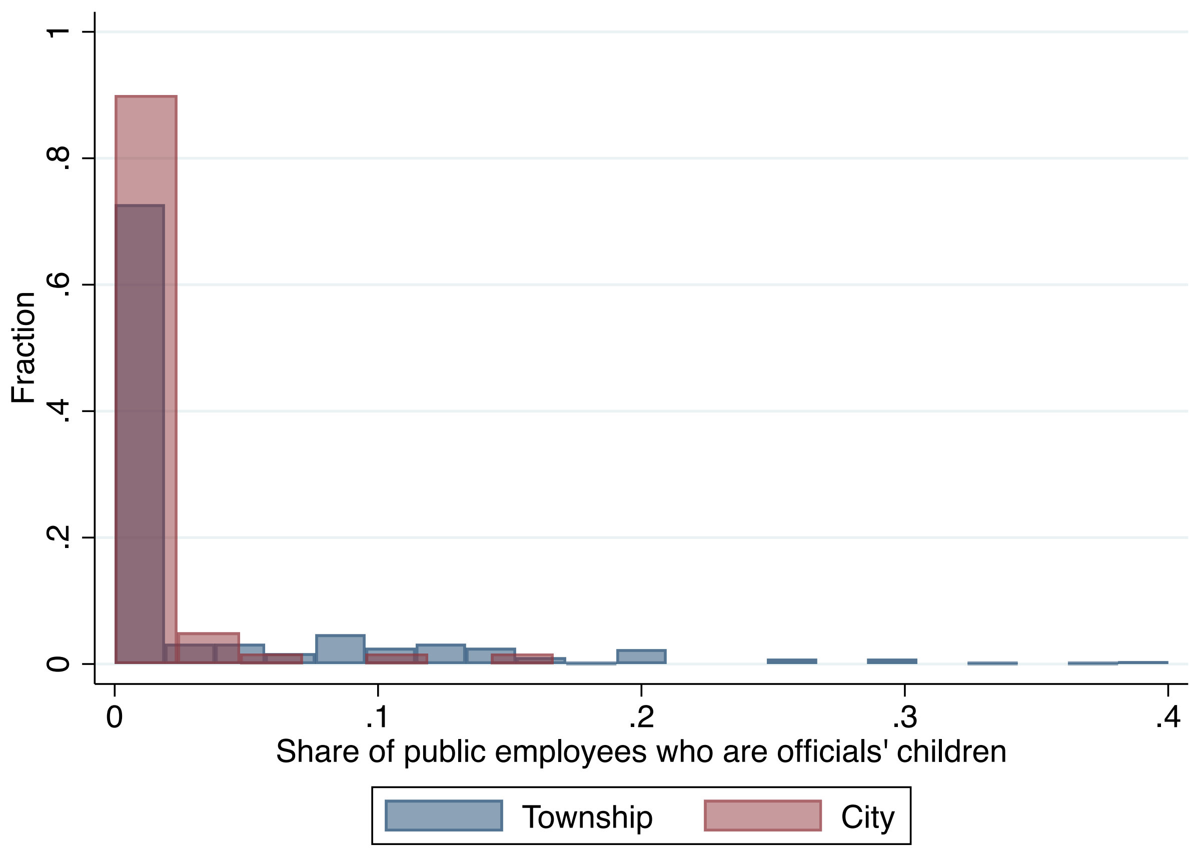


Figure A6. Distribution of Share of Officials' Sons in the Public Sector

Note: This figure plots the distribution of the share of public-sector employees who are sons of local officials, separately for townships and cities. The sample is restricted to localities with at least five public-sector employees observed in the 1930 Census.

B Additional Table

Table B1. List of Offices by Forms of Government

Government Form	Offices
Township	Clerk; Treasurer; Trustee; Justice of the Peace
Village	Assessor; Board of Education; Board of Public Affairs; Clerk; Commissioner; Health Officer; Manager; Marshal; Mayor; Members of Council; Solicitor; Street Commissioner; Treasurer
City	Assessors; Assistants; Auditor and Treasurer; Bailiff; Boards of Health, Education, Library, or Review; Chemist at Water Plant; Chief Justice; Chief of Police/Fire; City Attorney; City Engineer; City Manager; Civil Service Commission; Clerk; Commissioners of Accounts, Public Buildings, Treasury, Water; Directors of Finance, Law, and Public Services/Safety/Health; Judges; Mayor; Members of Council; Members of City Commission; Municipal Court; Members of Planning, Playground, Smoke Abatement, Sinking Fund, and Tax Commissions; Police Justice; Sanitary Officer; Solicitor; Superintendent; Vice Mayor; Vice President of Council

Note: This table presents the lists of offices reported in the rosters.

Table B2. Linking Roster to Census: Linking rate

	All		*City*		*Village*		*Township*	
	Link rate	Total	Link rate	Total	Link rate	Total	Link rate	Total
All	0.70	179952	0.72	21007	0.66	82559	0.73	76386
1912-1913	0.70	20866	0.71	2402	0.67	9266	0.73	9198
1914-1915	0.70	19398	0.72	1924	0.67	8396	0.73	9078
1916-1917	0.71	18432	0.74	1825	0.66	7570	0.74	9037
1918-1919	0.71	19735	0.74	2046	0.67	8673	0.75	9016
1920-1921	0.73	19385	0.73	1879	0.71	8800	0.75	8706
1922-1923	0.71	19880	0.72	2420	0.68	8681	0.75	8779
1924-1925	0.69	18754	0.72	2514	0.66	8767	0.71	7473
1926-1927	0.68	20627	0.70	2552	0.65	10600	0.72	7475
1928-1929	0.67	22875	0.70	3445	0.63	11806	0.71	7624

Note: This table presents the link rates of linking roster data to full-count individual censuses.

C Local Officials in Ohio

C.1 Ohio Rosters of Township and Municipal Officers

AKRON—POPULATION, 69,000.

Office.	Name of Officer.	Politics.	Term Expires.
Mayor	Isaac Myers	D	Jan. 1, 1920
President of Council	Jesse Merriman	R	Jan. 1, 1920
Auditor	Thomas Heffernan	D	Jan. 1, 1920
Treasurer	Wm. Hoover	D	Jan. 1, 1920
Solicitor	Scott D. Kenfield	R	Jan. 1, 1920
Police or Municipal Judge	John R. Vaughan	D	Jan. 1, 1919
Director of Public Service	Carl F. Beck	R	Jan. 10, 1918
Director of Public Safety	Charles R. Morgan	R	Jan. 10, 1918
Trustees of Sinking Fund and Board of Tax Commissioners	Joseph Winum	D	
	Armar Carnaham	R	
	P. Tobrie	D	
	W. H. Means	R	
Board of Healt'	George Kuhlke	D	
	A. B. Jones	R	
	Charles Hoffman	....	
	Dr. Armin Sicherman	....	
	Dr. Van der Hulse	....	
Board of Library Trustee	Harry L. Snyder	R	
	Jesse P. Dice	R	
	Hugh Allen	R	
	A. Holm	D	
	John Gross	D	
Board of Education	H. T. Waller	R	
	Mrs. A. Ross Read	....	
	J. Asa Palmer	D	
	D. W. Kaufman	R	
	C. W. Berry	R	
	C. M. Woodruff	R	
Chief of Police	John Durkin	D	Civil Service.
Chief of Fire Department	John T. Merty	R	Civil Service.
City Engineer	Earl Zeisloft	R	Civil Service.

Figure C1. Example page for city officials

ADAMS COUNTY.

Village.	Population.	Office.	Names.	Politics.	Term Expires.
Manchester	2,000	Mayor	A. H. Holderness	R	Dec. 31, 1919
		Clerk	S. N. Greenle	R	Dec. 31, 1919
		Treasurer	Guy Ellison	R	Dec. 31, 1919
		Marshal	Richard Harris	R	Dec. 31, 1919
		Members of Council	G. E. Neal	....	Dec. 31, 1919
			Robert Poole	....	Dec. 31, 1919
			Dan Grimsby	....	Dec. 31, 1919
			John Bell	....	Dec. 31, 1919
			Samuel Bath'arlomew	....	Dec. 31, 1919
		Board of Public Affairs	Ed. Smelling	....	
			Rufus McCormick	....	
			D. J. Slableton	....	
		Board of Education	John Koeple	....	Dec. 31, 1919
			J. C. Henderson	....	Dec. 31, 1919
			P. D. Vance	....	Dec. 31, 1921
			R. E. Shelton	....	Dec. 31, 1921
			Rufus Cox	....	Dec. 31, 1921
Peebles	....	Mayor	J. N. Askren	R	Jan. 1, 1920
		Clerk	H. B. Hunter	D	Jan. 1, 1920
		Treasurer	G. E. Henty	D	Jan. 1, 1920
		Marshal	Geo. Hoop	D	Jan. 1, 1920
		Members of Council	W. A. Thompson	D	Jan. 1, 1920
			C. C. Condon	R	Jan. 1, 1920
			E. W. Thomas	R	Jan. 1, 1920
			Harry Parker	D	Jan. 1, 1920
			Jacob Custer	D	Jan. 1, 1920
			M. T. Newman	R	Jan. 1, 1920
		Board of Education	C. A. Watts	....	Jan. 1, 1920
			D. W. Reynolds	....	Jan. 1, 1920
			P. A. Campbell	....	Jan. 1, 1920
			D. W. Shoemaker	....	Jan. 1, 1922
			E E. Mathias	....	Jan. 1, 1922
Seaman	600	Mayor	J. T. Ryan	D	Jan. 1, 1920
		Clerk	Homer King	R	Jan. 1, 1920
		Treasurer	F. G. Young	R	Jan. 1, 1920
		Marshal	John Hannah	D	Jan. 1, 1920
		Members of Council	C. E. Haas	D	Jan. 1, 1920
			C. E. Sturn	R	Jan. 1, 1920
			C. E. Heidrick	R	Jan. 1, 1920
			J. A. Caskey	R	Jan. 1, 1920
			C. W. Elmore	R	Jan. 1, 1920
			C. S. Moore	D	Jan. 1, 1920
		Board of Education	J. O. Kendall	R	Jan. 1, 1920
			H. A. Grooms	D	Jan. 1, 1922
			E. C. Zimmerman	R	Jan. 1, 1922

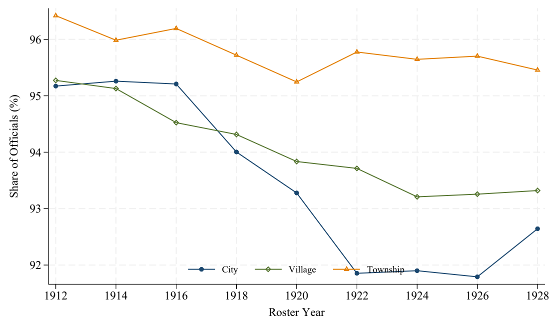
Figure C2. Example page for village officials

ADAMS COUNTY.

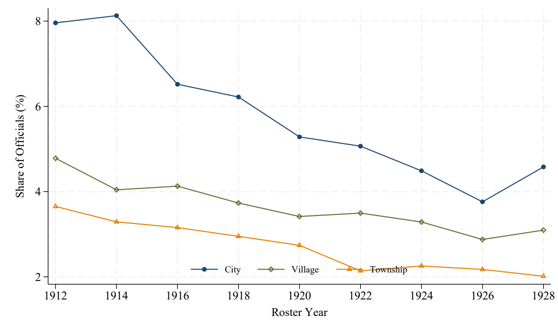
Township.	Names of Trustees.	Postoffice Address.
Bratton	Thomas Breslan	Peebles, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 2.
	Gilbert Smily	Peebles, Ohio.
	C. W. Jones	Peebles, Ohio.
Franklin	R. T. Copeland	Peebles, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 6.
	H. F. Hirdman	Peebles, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 6.
	S. E. Stodgel	Peebles, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 6.
Green	M. H. Ralston	Stout, Ohio.
	A. W. Foster	Sandy Springs, Ohio.
	Adam Richter	Buena Vista, Ohio.
Jefferson	N. W. Cross	Wamsley, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 1.
	Clayton Moore	Wamsley, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 1.
	W. D. Vogler	West Union, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 2.
Liberty	T. E. Shell	West Union, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 5.
	J. T. Moore	West Union, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 1.
	W. S. Jackson	West Union, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 1.
Manchester	J. N. Matthews	Manchester, Ohio.
	Grimes N. Morgan	Manchester, Ohio.
	W. H. Gray	Manchester, Ohio.
Meigs	W. P. Newman	Peebles, Ohio.
	T. J. Newman	Rarden, Ohio.
	H. C. Wright	Peebles, Ohio.
Monroe	Homer Baldwin	West Union, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 5.
	James Clark	Manchester, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 2.
	J. E. Young	West Union, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 4.
Oliver	Robbie Moore	West Union, Ohio.
	Earl Lewis	Peebles, Ohio.
	Wm. McClelland	West Union, Ohio.
Scott	J. C. McKenzie	Seaman, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 2.
	J. H. Plummer	Seaman, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 2.
	Jno. I. Cornelius	Peebles, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 2.
Sprigg	Charles Scott	Manchester, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 3.
	C. C. Harover	Manchester, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 1.
	Fred Kimble	Manchester, Ohio, R. F. D. No. 3.
Tiffin	J. C. Crawford	West Union, Ohio.
	J. A. Craigmile	West Union, Ohio.
	Wm. Shumaker	West Union, Ohio.
Wayne	J. M. Kepperling	Cherry Fork, Ohio.
	Edward Siddens	Peebles, Ohio, R. F. D.
	Ernest Shelton	Winchester, Ohio, R. F. D.
Winchester	R. C. Fulton	Winchester, Ohio.
	G. N. Baker	Winchester, Ohio.
	D. H. Pence	Winchester, Ohio.

Figure C3. Example page for township officials

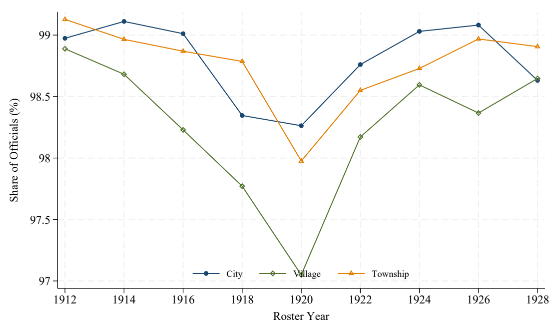
C.2 Who Are These Local Officials?



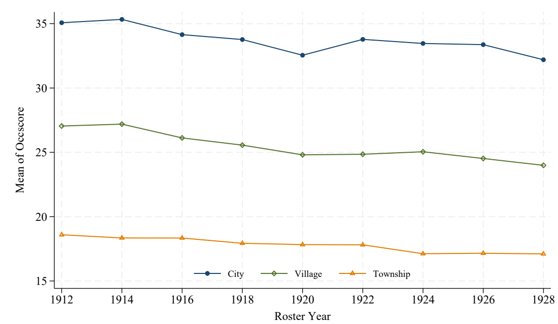
A. Male



B. Foreign born



C. Literacy



D. Pre-office occupational income score

Figure C4. Characteristics of Officials by Year

Note: This figure depicts the baseline characteristics of local officials by year and government format. Panels A, B, C, and D separately plot the trend of share of male officials, share of foreign-born officials, share of literate officials, and officials' average pre-office occupational income score.

D Validity of the Design

Table D1. Validity: Restricting to Officials First Observed After 1920

	Labor-Market Outcome$_{it}$		Occupation Category$_{it}$				Earning$_{1940}$
	(1) Log Occscore	(2) Log Occscore	(3) White collar	(4) Skilled blue collar	(5) Low skill	(6) Agricultural	(7) Log wage income
Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	0.032***	0.027***	0.029***	-0.016**	-0.001	-0.005	
	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.009)	(0.007)	
Office$_{j(i)}$	0.004						0.104***
	(0.008)						(0.026)
Individual FE		Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Pair FE							Y
Control Mean	22.382	22.382	0.214	0.147	0.394	0.240	1312.236
R^2	0.159	0.719	0.692	0.583	0.556	0.644	0.621
Observations	49555	49555	50815	50815	50815	50815	7949

Note: This table reports estimates of the effect of fathers' local officeholding on sons' labor-market outcomes, restricting the sample to sons of officials first observed entering office after 1920 and their matched controls. Columns (1)–(6) use the matched panel sample with the unit of observation being the individualcensus-year. Columns (1) and (2) examine log occupational income score (OCCSCORE), while Columns (3)–(6) examine indicators for employment in white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skill, and agricultural occupations, respectively. The sample includes matched sons who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office Census and are observed in 1900–1940. Column (7) uses a cross-sectional sample of matched sons observed in the 1940 Census and examines log wage income. Office equals one if individual i's father j ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post$_{it}$ equals one in census years after father j first enters office and zero before entry. Matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. The control mean reports the mean of the dependent variable in levels among matched controls in the estimation sample (mean of OCCSCORE for Columns (1)–(2) and mean of wage income for Column (7)). Standard errors are clustered at the father level in Columns (1)–(6) and at the matched-pair level in Column (7).
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

Table D2. Validity: Restricting to Young Sons

	Labor-Market Outcome$_{it}$		Occupation Category$_{it}$				Earning$_{1940}$
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
	Log Occscore	Log Occscore	White collar	Skilled blue collar	Low skill	Agricultural	Log wage income
Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	0.045***	0.039***	0.038***	-0.016**	-0.015	-0.004	
	(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.011)	(0.009)	
Office$_{j(i)}$	-0.008						0.095***
	(0.010)						(0.029)
Individual FE		Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Pair FE							Y
Control Mean	21.697	21.697	0.199	0.141	0.405	0.250	1292.504
R^2	0.180	0.726	0.697	0.586	0.562	0.640	0.598
Observations	44778	44778	45843	45843	45843	45843	7161

Note: This table reports estimates of the effect of fathers' local officeholding on sons' labor-market outcomes, restricting the sample to adult sons younger than age 28 when their fathers first enter office. Age 28 is the median age at fathers' office entry among officials' adult sons. Columns (1)–(6) use the matched panel sample with the unit of observation being the individualcensus-year. Columns (1) and (2) examine log occupational income score (OCCSCORE), while Columns (3)–(6) examine indicators for employment in white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skill, and agricultural occupations, respectively. The sample includes matched sons who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office Census and are observed in 1900–1940. Column (7) uses a cross-sectional sample of matched sons observed in the 1940 Census and examines log wage income. Office equals one if individual i's father j ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post$_{it}$ equals one in census years after father j first enters office and zero before entry. Matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. The control mean reports the mean of the dependent variable in levels among matched controls in the estimation sample (mean of OCCSCORE for Columns (1)–(2) and mean of wage income for Column (7)). Standard errors are clustered at the father level in Columns (1)–(6) and at the matched-pair level in Column (7).
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

Table D3. Validity: Excluding Potential Relatives from the Control Group

	Labor-Market Outcome$_{it}$		Occupation Category$_{it}$				Earning$_{1940}$
	(1) Log Occscore	(2) Log Occscore	(3) White collar	(4) Skilled blue collar	(5) Low skill	(6) Agricultural	(7) Log wage income
Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	0.030***	0.023***	0.024***	-0.008	-0.003	-0.007	
	(0.008)	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.006)	(0.009)	(0.007)	
Office$_{j(i)}$	0.006						0.114***
	(0.008)						(0.029)
Individual FE		Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Pair FE							Y
Control Mean	22.401	22.401	0.210	0.148	0.392	0.243	1319.284
R^2	0.185	0.719	0.684	0.578	0.542	0.638	0.609
Observations	52514	52514	53907	53907	53907	53907	7221

Note: This table reports estimates of the effect of fathers' local officeholding on sons' labor-market outcomes, reconstructing the matched sample after excluding potential controls who share a last name with any local official in the same county. Columns (1)–(6) use the matched panel sample with the unit of observation being the individualcensus-year. Columns (1) and (2) examine log occupational income score (OCCSCORE), while Columns (3)–(6) examine indicators for employment in white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skill, and agricultural occupations, respectively. The sample includes matched sons who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office Census and are observed in 1900–1940. Column (7) uses a cross-sectional sample of matched sons observed in the 1940 Census and examines log wage income. Office equals one if individual i's father j ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post$_{it}$ equals one in census years after father j first enters office and zero before entry. Matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. The control mean reports the mean of the dependent variable in levels among matched controls in the estimation sample (mean of OCCSCORE for Columns (1)–(2) and mean of wage income for Column (7)). Standard errors are clustered at the father level in Columns (1)–(6) and at the matched-pair level in Column (7).
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

Table D4. Validity: Excluding Officials with Only First-Name Initials Reported

	Labor-Market Outcome$_{it}$		Occupation Category$_{it}$				Earning$_{1940}$
	(1) Log Occscore	(2) Log Occscore	(3) White collar	(4) Skilled blue collar	(5) Low skill	(6) Agricultural	(7) Log wage income
Office$_{j(i)}$ $\times$ Post$_{it}$	0.019**	0.017*	0.008	-0.007	0.003	-0.005	
	(0.009)	(0.008)	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.010)	(0.008)	
Office$_{j(i)}$	0.000						0.127***
	(0.009)						(0.031)
Individual FE		Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
Pair FE							Y
Control Mean	22.040	22.040	0.207	0.142	0.389	0.255	1279.132
R^2	0.174	0.710	0.677	0.567	0.546	0.635	0.627
Observations	43843	43843	44971	44971	44971	44971	6065

Note: This table reports estimates of the effect of fathers' local officeholding on sons' labor-market outcomes, restricting the sample to sons of officials whose full first names are reported in the rosters and their matched controls. Columns (1)–(6) use the matched panel sample with the unit of observation being the individualcensus-year. Columns (1) and (2) examine log occupational income score (OCCSCORE), while Columns (3)–(6) examine indicators for employment in white-collar, skilled blue-collar, low-skill, and agricultural occupations, respectively. The sample includes matched sons who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office Census and are observed in 1900–1940. Column (7) uses a cross-sectional sample of matched sons observed in the 1940 Census and examines log wage income. Office equals one if individual i's father j ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post$_{it}$ equals one in census years after father j first enters office and zero before entry. Matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. The control mean reports the mean of the dependent variable in levels among matched controls in the estimation sample (mean of OCCSCORE for Columns (1)–(2) and mean of wage income for Column (7)). Standard errors are clustered at the father level in Columns (1)–(6) and at the matched-pair level in Column (7).
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

E Intergenerational Impact of Office

E.1 Intergenerational Impact on Daughters

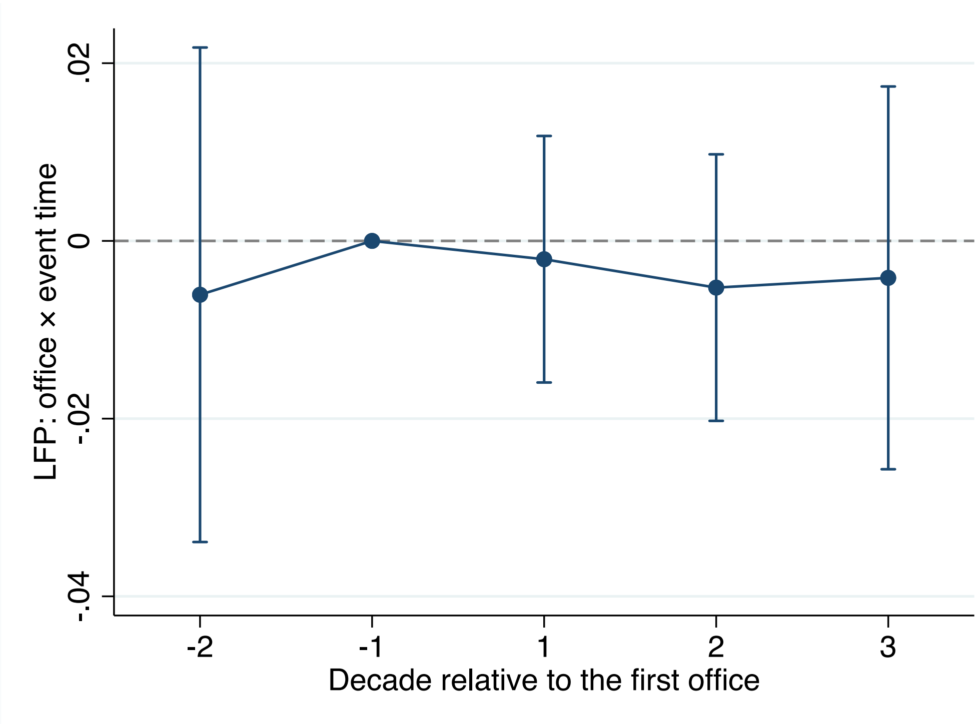


Figure E1. Dynamic Effect of Office on Daughters' Labor Force Participation
Note: This figure presents the dynamics of daughters' labor force participation from estimating Equation 2. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

E.1.1 Daughters' Marital Outcomes

I then examine whether fathers' officeholding affects whom their daughters marry. To do so, I link daughters to their husbands in the census and get information on husbands' characteristics when she is first observed married. Because spousal characteristics are observed only for married women residing in the same household as their husbands, this analysis is restricted to matched daughters who are observed as married and residing in the same household as their husbands. Moreover, since each daughter is observed only once at the census in which she first appears as married, the data structure is cross-sectional rather than panel. For these marriage-related outcomes, I estimate the following equation:

$$y_{ibcmt} = \alpha_m + \beta_1(\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}) + \beta_2\text{Post}_{it} + \theta_b + \mu_c + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{ibct} \tag{E1}$$

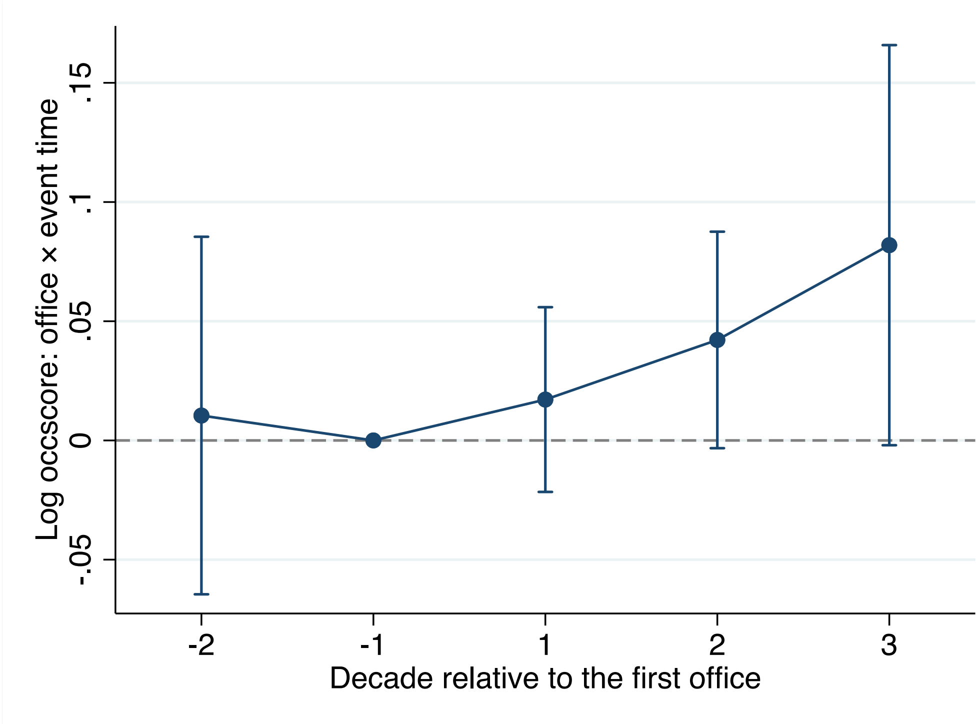


Figure E2. Dynamic Effect of Office on Daughters' Occupational Income

Note: This figure presents the dynamics of daughters' occupational income from estimating Equation 2. The sample includes only working daughters. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

where m indexes the matched pairs generated in the matching procedure described in Section 3.1, and α_m denotes the matched pair fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the matched-pair level. The outcomes of interest, y_{ibcmt}, are husbands' characteristics when the daughter is first observed married, including occupation, occupational income score, and family background, proxied by the father-in-law's occupational income score.

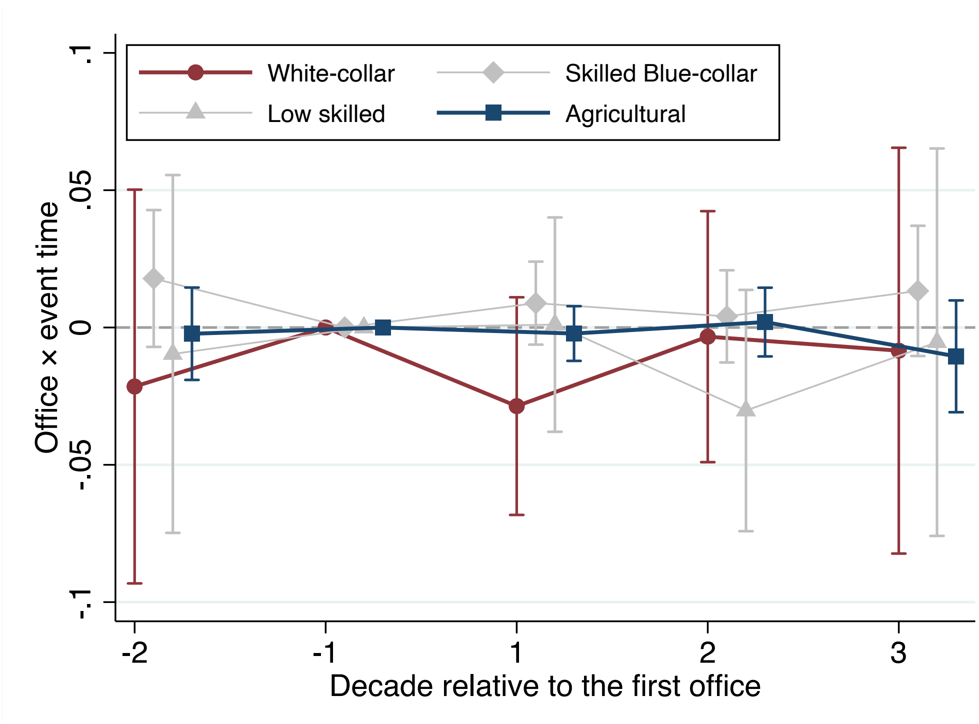


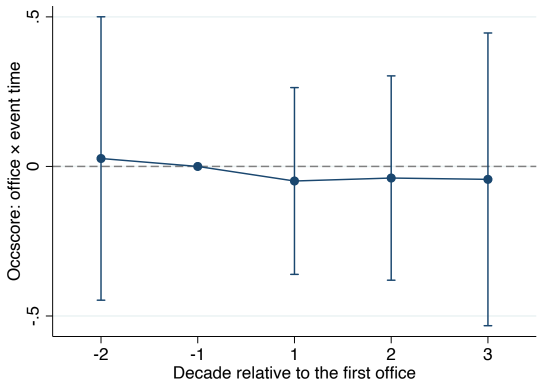
Figure E3. Dynamic Effect of Office on Daughters' Occupation

Note: This figure presents the dynamics of daughters' occupational categories from estimating Equation 2. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

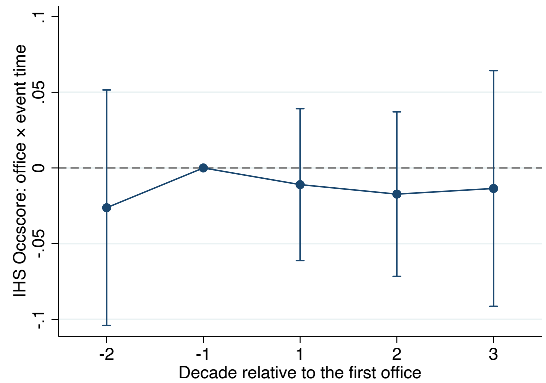
Table E1. Occupational Outcomes for All Daughters: Alternative Functional Forms

	(1) IHS	(2) Level	(3) PPML
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	-0.008	-0.050	-0.007
	(0.023)	(0.142)	(0.035)
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	3.388	3.388	9.421
R^2	0.517	0.531	
Observations	94853	94853	94853

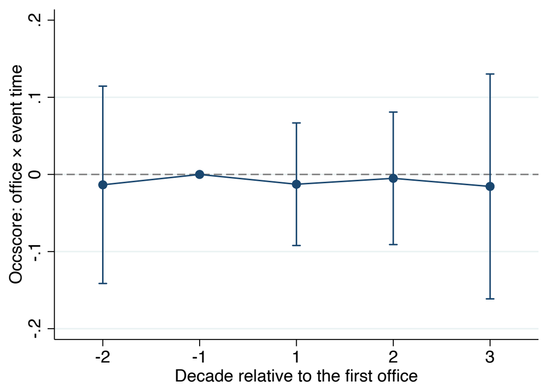
Note: This table reports estimates of the effect of fathers' officeholding on daughters' occupational outcomes using alternative transformations and estimation methods. The unit of observation is the individual-census-year. Column (1) uses the inverse hyperbolic sine transformation of OCCSCORE and Column (2) uses levels of OCCSCORE. Column (3) estimates a Poisson pseudo-maximum-likelihood (PPML) specification. All outcomes are defined for the full sample of daughters, with OCCSCORE set to zero for daughters who are not working. The sample includes matched daughters who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office census and are observed in the 1900–1940 Censuses. Office equals one if individual i's father j ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post_{it} equals one in census years after father j first enters office and zero before entry; matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. The control mean reports the mean of OCCSCORE in levels among matched controls in the estimation sample. Standard errors are clustered at the father level.
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$



A. Occscore



B. IHS Occscore



C. Occscore (PPML)

Figure E4. Occupational Outcomes for All Daughters: Alternative Functional Forms

Note: This figure presents event-study estimates of the effect of fathers' officeholding on unconditional occupational outcomes for daughters. The sample includes all matched daughters of working age, with OCCSCORE set to zero for daughters who are not working. Panel A uses OCCSCORE in levels, Panel B uses the inverse hyperbolic sine transformation of OCCSCORE, and Panel C estimates a Poisson pseudo-maximum-likelihood specification with OCCSCORE as the outcome. Event time is measured in census decades relative to the father's first entry into office, with the decade immediately preceding office entry omitted as the reference period. Points show coefficient estimates and bars indicate 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered at the father level.

Table E2. Intergenerational impact on daughters' marital outcomes

	Marital: Husband			
	(1) White collar	(2) Public sector	(3) Log Occscore	(4) Log Father Occscore
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.009	-0.002	0.071	-0.066
	(0.063)	(0.004)	(0.054)	(0.052)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Pair FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	0.144	0.001	20.085	17.539
R^2	0.580	0.582	0.630	0.602
Observations	9855	9855	9663	9395

Note: This table reports cross-sectional estimates of the effect of fathers' officeholding on daughters' marital matches. The sample consists of matched daughters who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office census and are observed married in at least one census between 1900 and 1940. Each daughter enters the sample once, using the first census in which she is observed married. The dependent variables are an indicator for the husband being employed in a white-collar occupation in Column (1), an indicator for the husband being employed in the public sector in Column (2), the log occupational income score (OCCSCORE) of the husband in Column (3), and the log OCCSCORE of the husband's father in Column (4). Office equals one if the daughter's father ever holds local office and zero otherwise. Post equals one if the census in which the daughter is first observed married occurs after her father first enters office and zero otherwise; matched controls are assigned the office-entry timing of their treated counterparts. All specifications include age-bin, matched-pair, county, and census-year fixed effects. The control mean reports the mean of the dependent variable in levels among matched controls. Standard errors are clustered at the matched-pair level.
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

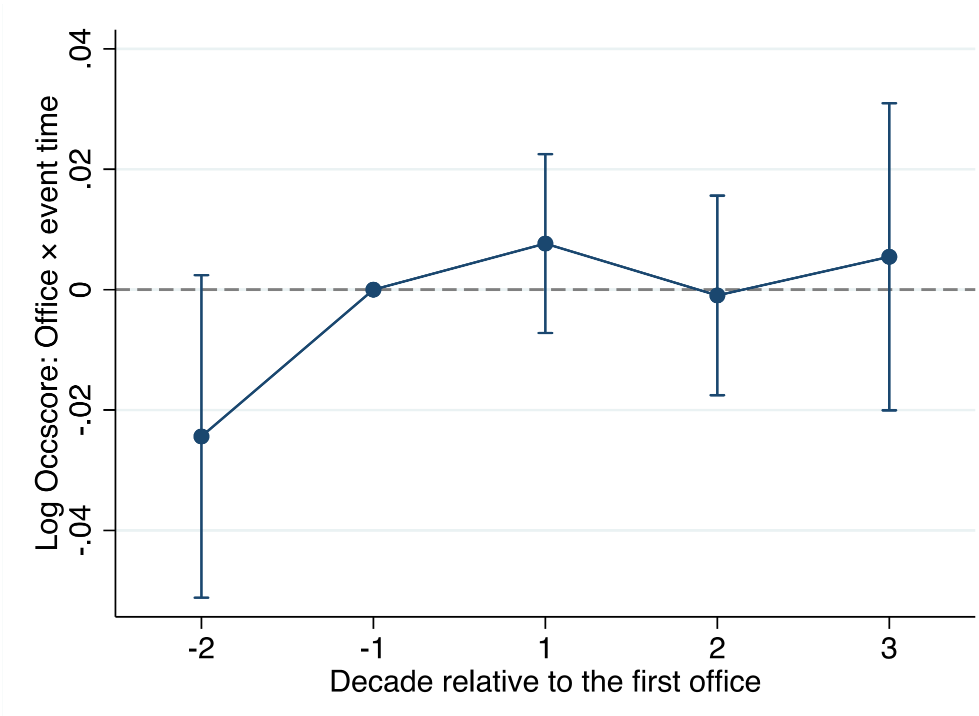


Figure E5. Dynamic Effects of Fathers-in-Law's Officeholding on Sons-in-Law's OCCSCORE

Note: This figure presents event-study estimates of the effect of fathers-in-law's officeholding on sons-in-law's occupational income scores from estimating Equation 2. The sample includes daughters and their matched counterparts who were married before their fathers start the offices. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

E.2 Heterogeneity of the Impact

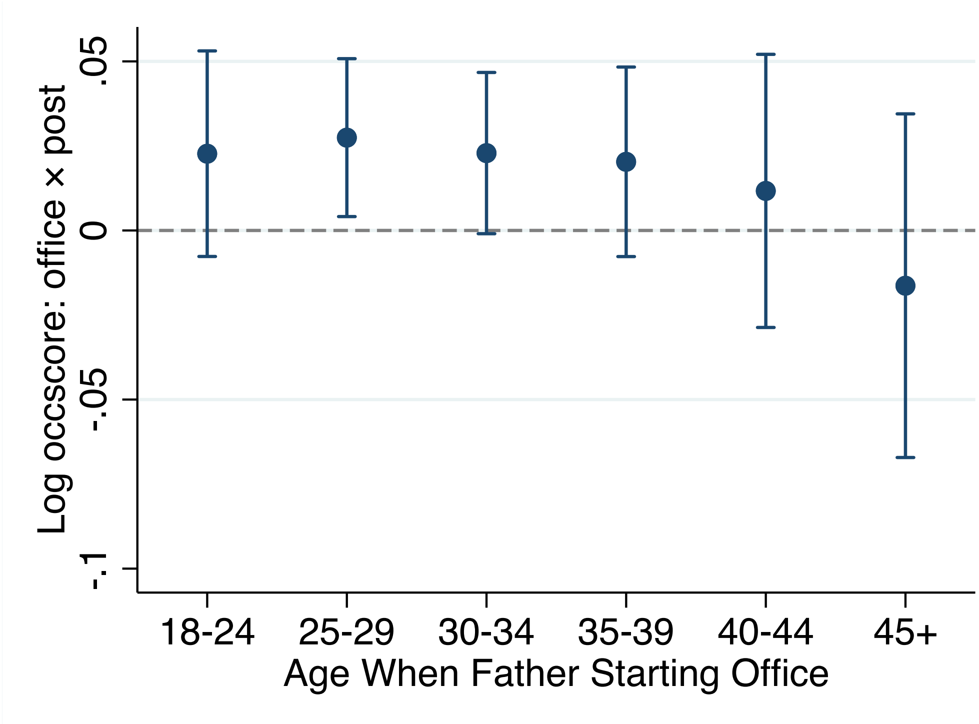


Figure E6. Heterogeneity of Officeholding on Son's Occupational Income

Note: This figure presents heterogeneity in the estimated effect of fathers' officeholding on sons' log occupational income by sons' age when their fathers first entered office. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

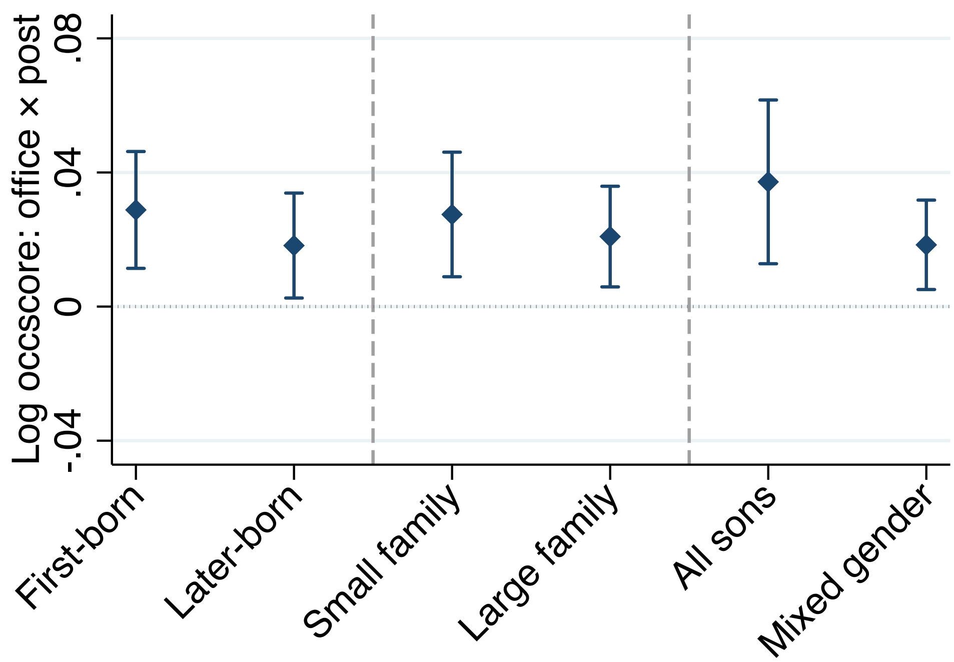


Figure E7. Heterogeneity of Officeholding on Son's Occupational Income

Note: This figure presents heterogeneity in the estimated effect of fathers' officeholding on sons' log occupational income by sibling composition. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

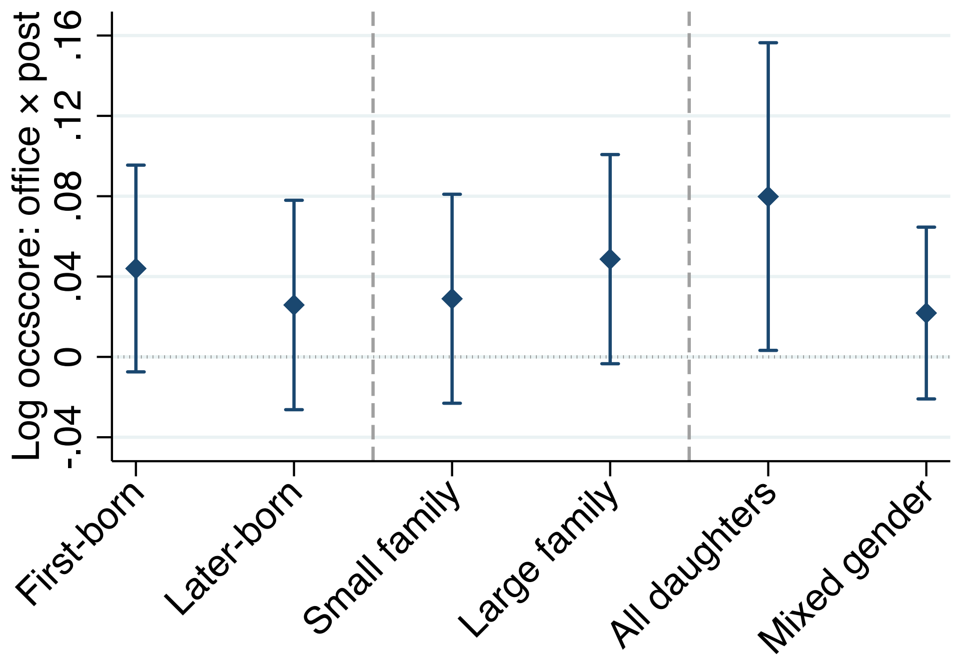


Figure E8. Heterogeneity of Officeholding on Daughter's Occupational Income

Note: This figure presents heterogeneity in the estimated effect of fathers' officeholding on working daughters' log occupational income by sibling composition. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

E.3 Robustness Check

Table E3. Robustness: Alternative Inference

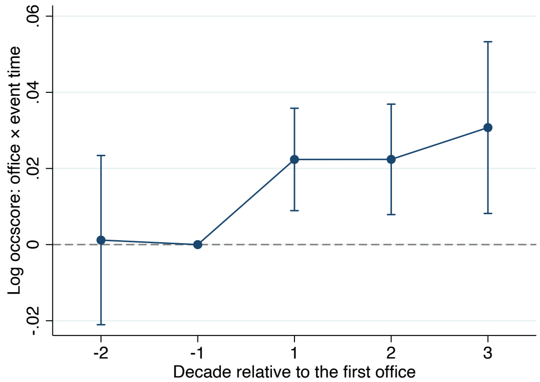
	Clustering at the level of			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
	Father	Individual	Matched pair	County
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.0229***	0.0229***	0.0229***	0.0229***
	(0.0062)	(0.0060)	(0.0062)	(0.0056)
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	22.133	22.133	22.133	22.133
R^2	0.715	0.715	0.715	0.715
Observations	81981	81981	81981	81981

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on sons' occupational income with standard errors clustered at different levels. The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. The dependent variables are log occupational income score. The sample includes all matched individuals who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office census and the data is collected in the census 1900 to 1940. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors in Column (1) to (4) are separately clustered at the level of fathers, the level of individuals, matched pairs, and counties.
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$

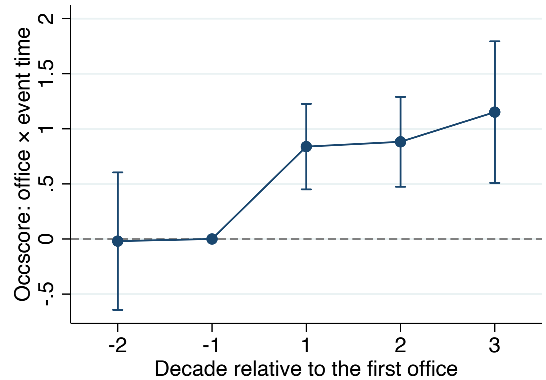
Table E4. Robustness: Alternative Outcome Measures and Specification

	IPUMS Occscore$_{it}$			LIDO Score$_{it}$		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Log	Level	PPML	Log	Level	PPML
Office$_{j(i)}$ × Post$_{it}$	0.023***	0.893***	0.040***	0.022***	0.580***	0.026***
	(0.006)	(0.174)	(0.009)	(0.006)	(0.164)	(0.008)
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Control Mean	22.133	20.261	20.261	22.260	20.880	20.880
R^2	0.715	0.605		0.672	0.590	
Observations	81981	89690	89690	73306	76363	76363

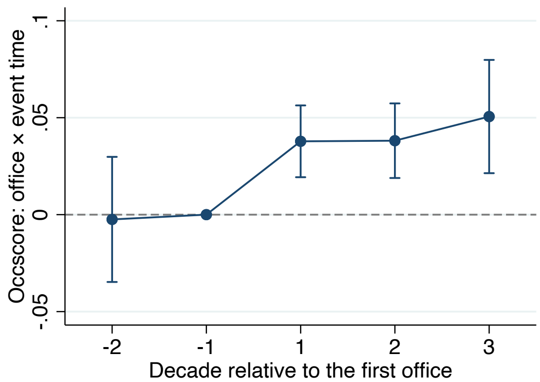
Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on sons' occupational income using different outcome measures (Columns (1), (2), (4), and (5)) and estimation specifications (Columns (3) and (6)). The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. The dependent variables for Columns (1) to (2) are log and level of occupational income score obtained from IPUMS; and for (4) to (5) are log and level of Lasso-Industry-Demographic-Occupation (LIDO) score obtained from Saavedra and Twinam (2020). Note the sample size for LIDO score is smaller because Saavedra and Twinam (2020) constructed the score variable for individuals aged 25 and above. Columns (3) and (6) implement the pseudo Poisson maximum likelihood (PPML) estimation on outcomes of OCCSCORE and LIDO score. The sample includes all matched individuals who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office census and the data is collected in the census 1900 to 1940. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post$_{it}$ is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$



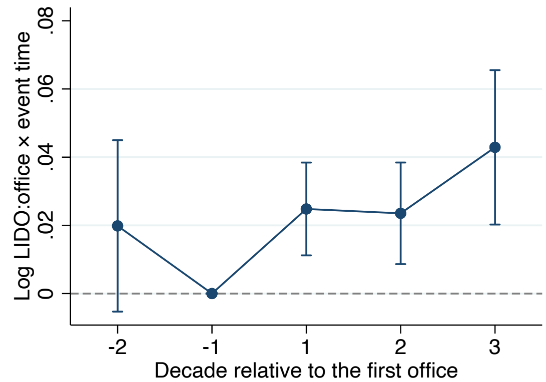
A. Log Occscore



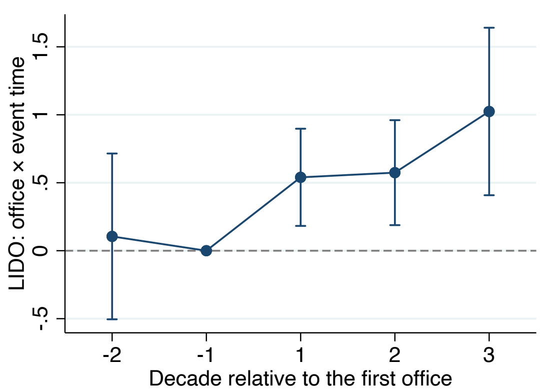
B. Occscore



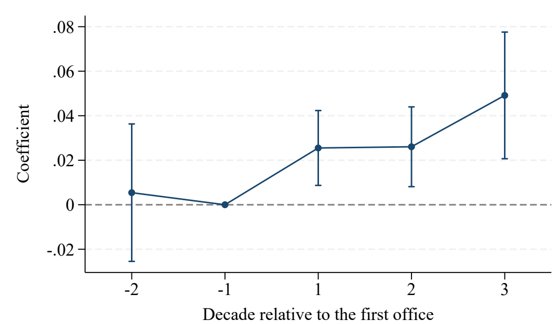
C. PPML: Occscore



D. Log LIDO Score



E. LIDO Score



F. PPML: LIDO Score

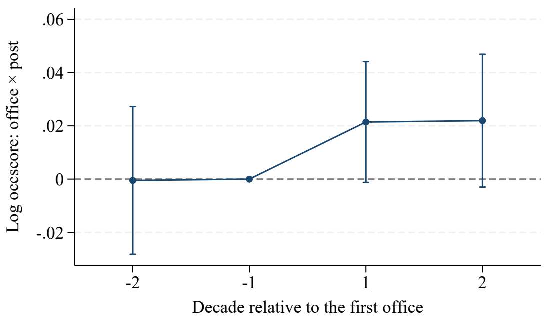
Figure E9. Robustness: Alternative Outcome Measures and Specification

Note: This figure presents the event study plots using alternative outcome measures and specifications. Panels A–C use occupational income score (OCCSCORE). Panel A uses log OCCSCORE, Panel B uses OCCSCORE in levels, and Panel C estimates a Poisson pseudo-maximum-likelihood (PPML) specification. Panels D–F report the corresponding estimates using the Lasso-Industry-Demographic-Occupation (LIDO) score from Saavedra and Twinam (2020) The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

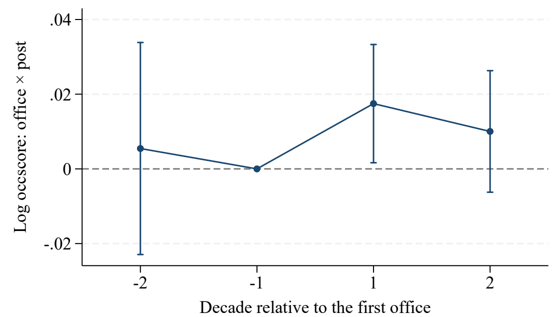
Table E5. Robustness: Alternative Sample

	(1) Balanced Panel	(2) Office 1914-1920	(3) Office 1920-1928
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.022^{**}	0.022^{***}	0.027^{***}
	(0.010)	(0.008)	(0.008)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y
Mean	22.921	22.624	23.075
R^2	0.715	0.712	0.719
Observations	20351	49928	49555

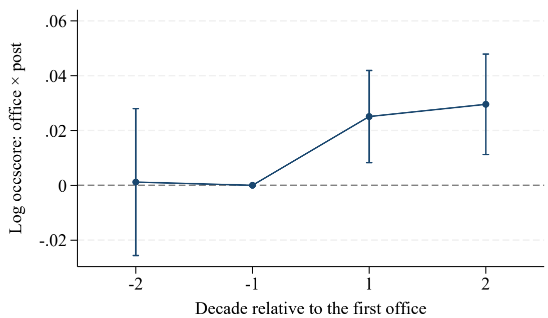
Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on sons' occupational income using different samples. The dependent variables are log occupational income score. The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. Column (1) uses a fully balanced sample. Column (2) uses the sample of sons of officials who started their office between 1914 and 1920 and their matched counterparts. Column (3) uses the sample of sons of officials who started their office between 1920 and 1928 and their matched counterparts. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.
* $p < 0.1$ ** $p < 0.05$ *** $p < 0.01$



A. Balanced Panel



B. Office 1914-1920



C. Office 1920-1928

Figure E10. Robustness: Alternative Sample

Note: This figure presents the event study plots using alternative samples. Note that for individuals whose fathers started offices after 1920, there are only 2 post periods given the access to the full count census in 1940. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

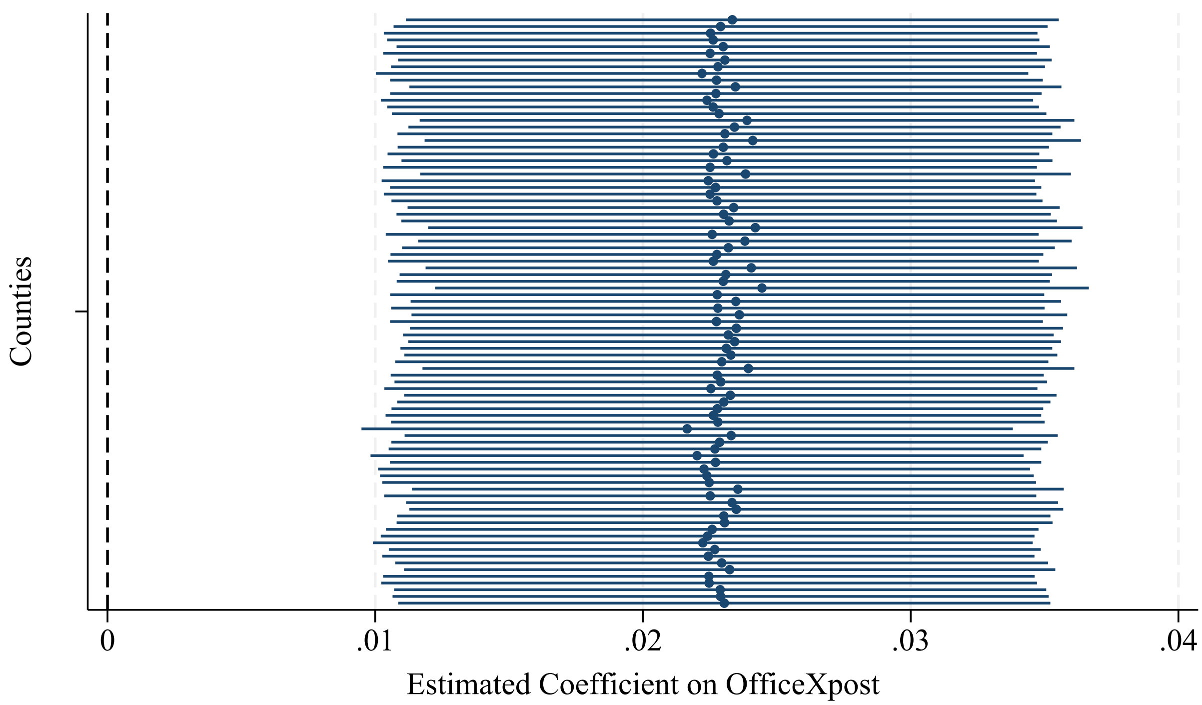


Figure E11. Robustness: Dropping One County Each Time

Note: This figure presents the coefficient on Office $\times$ Post from Equation 1, using the entire sample excluding one county at a time. The solid dots are point estimates, and the caps are the 95 percent confidence intervals. Standard errors clustered at the father level are used for constructing the confidence intervals.

F Other Potential Mechanisms

Table F1. Testing Occupational Inheritance

	Broad category		Detailed category	
	(1) Same industry	(2) Same occupation	(3) Same industry	(4) Same occupation
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	-0.006	0.005	-0.001	0.007
	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.006)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y
Mean	0.408	0.298	0.376	0.260
R^2	0.626	0.555	0.648	0.571
Observations	89690	89690	89690	89690

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on the probability of getting into their fathers' pre-office ($t = -1$) jobs. The dependent variables are dummy variables equal to one if the individual is employed in their father's pre-office industry (Columns (1) and (3)) or occupation (Columns (2) and (4)). Columns (1) and (2) use the broader definition of industry and occupation, while Columns (3) and (4) use the finest definition of industry and occupation provided in IND1950 and OCC1950 variable in Censuses. The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.

Table F2. Testing Marriage Network

	Wife's Father		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
	Log occscore	White-collar	Public sector
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	-0.048	-0.017	-0.001
	(0.043)	(0.037)	(0.007)
$\text{Office}_{j(i)}$	0.016	0.023*	0.003
	(0.016)	(0.012)	(0.004)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y
Pair FE	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y
Mean	18.788	0.096	0.007
R^2	0.625	0.591	0.579
Observations	8768	9005	8733

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on sons' marital outcomes. The sample consists of married individuals and are therefore cross-sectional. Columns (1) to (3) examine characteristics of the wife's family in the first census where the son is observed as married: the log occupational income score (occscore) of the wife's father, whether the wife's father works in white-collar jobs, and whether the wife's father works in the public sector. The sample includes all matched individuals who are at least 18 years old in the pre-office census and the data is collected in the census 1900 to 1940. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the match pair level.

Table F3. Testing Reputation Channel

	Log Occupational Income		Public-sector		Private-sector White-collar	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Common	Rare	Common	Rare	Common	Rare
$\text{Office}_{j(i)} \times \text{Post}_{it}$	0.024***	0.020**	0.014***	0.009***	0.012	0.019**
	(0.008)	(0.009)	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.008)	(0.008)
Age bin FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Individual FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
County FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Year FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Mean	22.7595	22.9564	0.0207	0.0236	0.2104	0.2209
R^2	0.7129	0.7171	0.4947	0.5229	0.6342	0.6392
Observations	39055	39850	41990	42774	41990	42774

Note: This table reports regression estimates of the effect of political office on sons' occupational income and probability of getting employed in white-collar jobs in the private sector by the frequency of their last names. The dependent variables for Columns (1) and (2) are sons' log occupational income score; for Columns (3) and (4) are binary variables equal to one if officials' sons work in the public sector; and for Columns (5) and (6) are binary variables equal to one if officials' sons work in white-collar jobs in the private sector. Samples in Columns (1), (3), and (5) include sons of officials with common surnames defined by surname frequency larger than the median of the surname frequency among the sample; while Columns (2), (4), and (6) include sons of officials with less common surnames defined by surname frequency lower than the median of the surname frequency in the sample. The unit of observation is at the individual-year level. Office is a binary variable equal to 1 if the individual's father is ever a local official, and 0 otherwise. Post_{it} is a dummy equal to 0 if i's father j hasn't started the term in year t, and 1 otherwise. The standard errors are clustered at the father level.

G Exploring the Downstream Effects

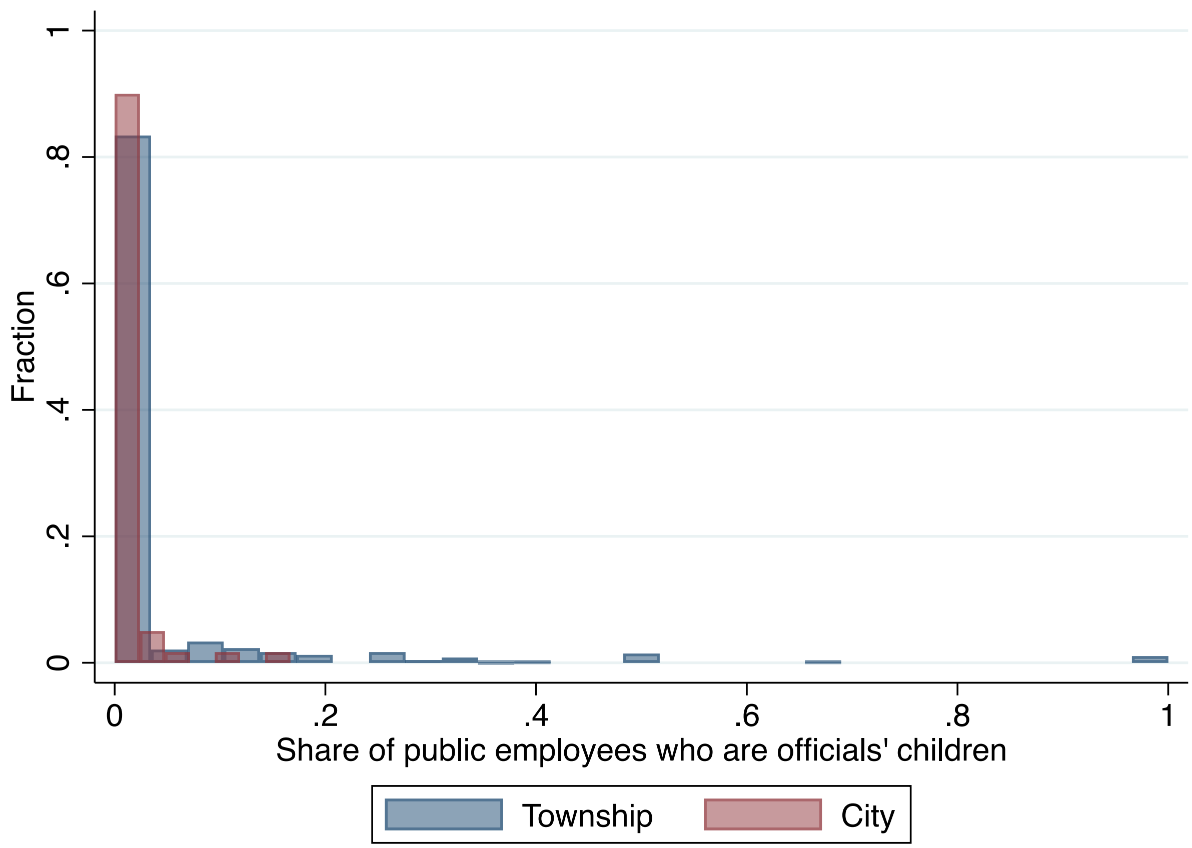


Figure G1. Distribution of Share of Officials' Sons in the Public Sector (Full Sample)

Note: This figure plots the distribution of the share of public-sector employees who are sons of local officials, separately for townships and cities. The sample does not have any restriction on the size of public sector employees.

Table G1. Downstream Effect of Intergenerational Political Rents (Full Sample)

	Township				City			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
	Gini	Gini	Top-10% Share	Top-10% Share	Gini	Gini	Top-10% Share	Top-10% Share
Share of politicians' sons in pub (sd)	0.005**		0.005*		-0.001		0.002	
	(0.002)		(0.003)		(0.002)		(0.002)	
Sons in pub		0.020***		0.020***		-0.007		0.004
		(0.006)		(0.006)		(0.012)		(0.011)
Controls	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Dependent Mean	0.612	0.612	0.376	0.376	0.455	0.455	0.271	0.271
R^2	0.646	0.648	0.582	0.585	0.618	0.621	0.487	0.487
Observations	957	957	957	957	60	60	60	60

Note: This table reports locality-level regressions of income inequality in 1940 on exposure to officials' sons in public employment in 1930. Columns (1)–(4) use the township sample, and Columns (5)–(8) use the city sample. The dependent variables are the Gini coefficient in Columns (1), (2), (5), and (6), and the share of wage income accruing to the top 10 percent of workers in Columns (3), (4), (7), and (8). Share of officials' sons in pub (sd) is the standardized share of public-sector employees who are sons of local officials. *Sons in pub* is a binary variable equal to one if at least one public-sector employee residing in the locality is the son of a local official. All specifications control for the male, white, native-born, urban, employment, agricultural-employment, and public-employment shares, log population, and the 1930 Gini coefficient constructed from occupational income scores. Standard errors are clustered at the county level.

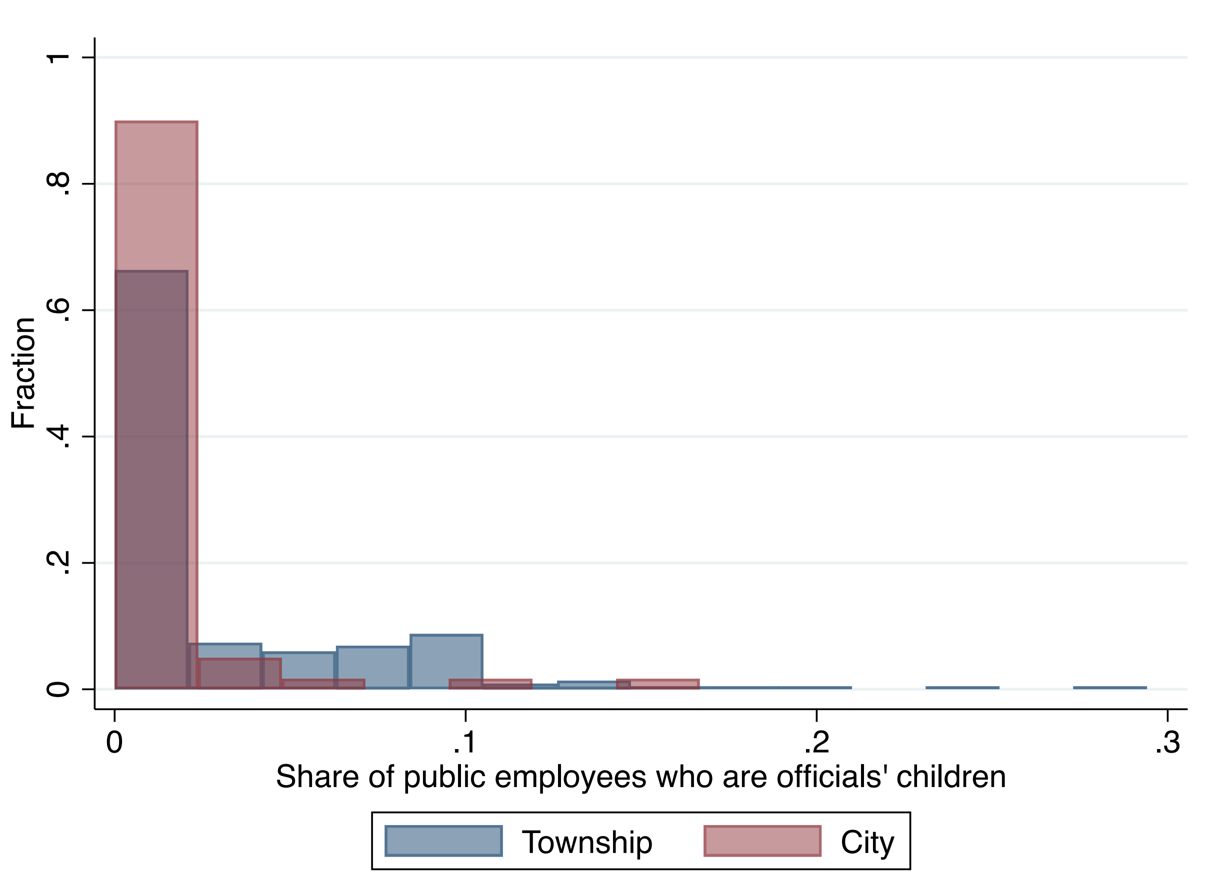


Figure G2. Distribution of Share of Officials' Sons in the Public Sector ($\geq$ 10 public employees)

Note: This figure plots the distribution of the share of public-sector employees who are sons of local officials, separately for townships and cities. The sample is restricted to localities with at least ten public-sector employees observed in the 1930 Census.

Table G2. Downstream Effect of Intergenerational Political Rents ($\geq$ 10 public employees)

	Township				City			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
	Gini	Gini	Top-10% Share	Top-10% Share	Gini	Gini	Top-10% Share	Top-10% Share
Share of politicians' sons in pub (sd)	0.015		0.021^{*}		-0.001		0.002	
	(0.013)		(0.011)		(0.002)		(0.002)	
Sons in pub		0.015^{*}		0.021^{***}		-0.007		0.004
		(0.009)		(0.007)		(0.012)		(0.011)
Controls	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Dependent Mean	0.552	0.552	0.323	0.323	0.455	0.455	0.271	0.271
R^2	0.656	0.658	0.577	0.585	0.618	0.621	0.487	0.487
Observations	217	217	217	217	60	60	60	60

Note: This table reports locality-level regressions of income inequality in 1940 on exposure to officials' sons in public employment in 1930. The sample includes cities and townships with public employees size larger than 10. Columns (1)–(4) use the township sample, and Columns (5)–(8) use the city sample. The dependent variables are the Gini coefficient in Columns (1), (2), (5), and (6), and the share of wage income accruing to the top 10 percent of workers in Columns (3), (4), (7), and (8). Share of officials' sons in pub (sd) is the standardized share of public-sector employees who are sons of local officials. *Sons in pub* is a binary variable equal to one if at least one public-sector employee residing in the locality is the son of a local official. All specifications control for the male, white, native-born, urban, employment, agricultural-employment, and public-employment shares, log population, and the 1930 Gini coefficient constructed from occupational income scores. Standard errors are clustered at the county level.